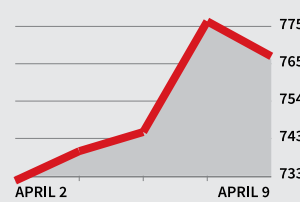


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 76631.65 (-931.25)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23775.10	-222.25
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	21.06	-0.26
US Dollar (in ₹)	92.65	+0.07
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	149337.00	-1179
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	236158.00	-7883

DROP IN PRODUCTION.

Unseasonal rain in March and April has hit the wheat crop across 111 districts in nine States, leading to a 5-10% drop in output **p10**



US TRADE TALKS.

As India and the US look to revive trade deal talks, a team heads to Washington this month **p3**

QUICKLY.

CAFE-3 SHAKE-UP

Centre likely to ease norms for small cars



New Delhi: The upcoming Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency-3 (CAFE-3) norms are likely to offer significant concessions to small cars, marking a decisive tilt in favour of entry-level and compact vehicles even as emission targets tighten sharply for large, fuel-intensive SUVs. **p2**

FRAGILE CEASEFIRE

Markets snap 5-day winning streak

Mumbai: Markets reversed course on Thursday, with the benchmark indices declining after five consecutive sessions of gains, as investor optimism around a US-Iran ceasefire quickly gave way to renewed geopolitical anxiety. The BSE Sensex fell 931 points to close at 76,631, while the Nifty 50 shed 222 points to end at 23,766. The sell-off followed Wednesday's sharp 1,800-point rally that was triggered by ceasefire signals that appeared increasingly fragile by Thursday afternoon. **p6**

TCS Q4 net up 12% on AI-led revenue growth, order book

POSITIVE SHOW. Operating margin remains stable at 25.3%; salary hikes for all grades

Vallari Sanzgiri

Mumbai

Tata Consultancy Services' net profit rose 12 per cent to ₹13,784 crore for the fourth quarter of 2025-26, led by revenue growth and larger order bookings. Net profit increased by 28.5 per cent on a sequential basis, owing to one-off expenses in the previous quarter.

CEO and MD K Krithivasan said, "We are pleased to report the third consecutive quarter of sequential growth, supported by three mega deals and a \$12 billion TCV. This momentum was broad-based across major markets and most industries. While macro-economic headwinds continue, we see sustained customer conviction in technology investments, which positions us well for the opportunities ahead."

Revenue grew 9.6 per cent to ₹70,698 crore y-o-y, and 5.3 per cent on a quarterly basis. However, on a constant currency basis, FY26 reported around 2.4 per cent annual decline, the com-

Results at a glance

	Q4 FY25	Q3 FY26	Q4 FY26
Revenue (₹ crore)	64,479	67,087	70,698
PAT (₹ crore)	12,293	10,720	13,784
Headcount	6,07,979	5,82,163	5,84,519
Attrition (%)	13.3	13.5	13.7
TCV (\$ billion)	12.2	9.3	12

pany's first revenue dip since going public, as per Phil Fresht, Founder and CEO, HFS Research. Forex was a key uptick, with exchange difference on translation of foreign currency cash and cash equivalents going from ₹174 crore in Q4FY25 to ₹959 crore in Q4FY26.

AI REVENUES UP

Annualised AI revenues surpassed \$2.3 billion, driven by accelerated deployment of AI solutions. During its analyst call, the management estimated AI revenues to grow and make up for the potential reduction in traditional revenue segments.

The total contract value (TCV) increased 29 per cent to \$12 billion, with three mega-deal wins in Q4. The operating margin remained

stable at 25.3 per cent. TCS announced annual salary increases across all grades effective April 1, with top performers getting double-digit rises.

Sudeep Kunnumal, Chief HR Officer, said, "We are pleased to implement annual salary increases across all grades, effective April 1. In Q4, we continued to invest in a future-ready workforce with strong additions across experienced talent and campus hires." Workforce grew by 2,356 to 5,84,519 employees, a sequential growth of 0.4 per cent. The company reported a 'Voluntary' LTM attrition of 13.7 per cent.

REGIONAL MARKETS

In Q4, regional markets grew 1.2 per cent sequentially. The Indian market reported a 1.7



K Krithivasan, CEO

per cent sequential growth. The UK market grew 2.4 per cent, and West Asia and Africa rose 0.4 per cent sequentially. Latin America, however, dropped 6.9 per cent. Aside from regional markets, the BFSI, consumer business and life-sciences and healthcare verticals continued to lead growth.

Asked about West Asia war, Krithivasan said there was no disruption beyond travel and transport restrictions, but spoke of potential impact in case of supply chain disruption.

On its HyperVault data centre ambitions, the management reported significant engagement across the full ecosystem of hyperscaler, semiconductor companies and model providers.

Analysis **p2**

Banks rush to unwind long dollar positions ahead of RBI's April 10 deadline

Our Bureau

Mumbai

Banks seem to have more or less closed out their excessive speculative and arbitrage positions in the forex market ahead of the RBI's April 10 deadline to unwind long dollar positions, going by the gains the rupee has made so far, according to sources, who estimated that almost 90 per cent of these positions may have been unwound.

With the rupee last month breaching 95 per US dollar intra-day, surpassing its previous record lows amid concerns over the West Asia conflict, the RBI introduced a prudential measure on March 27 (post market hours) to ensure orderly conditions in the foreign exchange market.

PRUDENTIAL MEASURE

As per the prudential measure, authorised dealers/ADS (banks) have to limit their net open position in INR (NOP-INR) in the onshore deliverable market to within \$100 million at the end of each business day. This is to ensure orderly conditions in the foreign exchange market.

Following the aforementioned measures, the rupee has so far (up to April 9)



The move will ensure orderly conditions in the foreign exchange market GETTY IMAGES

gained about 200 paise against the dollar in six trading sessions, beginning March 27.

Amit Pabari, MD, CR Forex Advisors, said the RBI stepped in at a critical juncture through its March 27 circular, capping banks' Net Open Position (NOP-INR) at \$100 million, with compliance mandated by April 10. This move came when the rupee was under significant depreciation pressure.

"Market estimates suggested that banks were required to unwind positions worth \$18-30 billion. This unwinding effectively translated into sustained dollar selling and rupee buying, providing near-term support to the currency," Pabari said.

He assessed that with the bulk of NOP-related support now fading and global uncer-

tainties still elevated, the rupee's near-term strength appears limited. USD-INR is likely to find a base in the 92.20-92.50 zone, with a gradual move higher towards 93.50-94.

GEOPOLITICAL CRISIS

He said initially, expectations were that this regulatory intervention, coupled with any easing in geopolitical tensions, particularly the West Asia war, would help stabilise the rupee.

However, recent developments underscore the fragility of the ceasefire, with fresh escalation involving Israel and renewed disruptions around the Strait of Hormuz emerging within hours of the pause announcement, keeping global uncertainties elevated.

"This has reignited upside pressure on crude oil prices... Elevated crude prices directly widen India's import bill, thereby exerting renewed pressure on the rupee," he said.

Referring to losses incurred by some banks due to the prudential measures, a forex dealer said, "Instead of the knee-jerk reaction, which cut the position limits, RBI should have called up bank treasuries to unwind their long positions slowly."

+ NSE pushing to file IPO papers by early May

Janaki Krishnan

Mumbai

The National Stock Exchange of India is pushing to file by the first week of May the draft red herring prospectus for its initial public offer in the region of ₹23,000 crore, said sources.

Investment bankers working on the issue have been given a strict timeline to get the documentation ready so that the papers can be filed with the Securities and Exchange Board of India by May 8, according to sources in the know.

RACE AGAINST TIME

While the intermediaries are racing against time to comply with the deadline, the NSE is also getting its annual accounts ready by that time. Sources indicate that a board meeting is scheduled towards the end of April to ap-



TIGHT TIMELINE. Investment bankers have been given a strict timeline to get the documentation ready REUTERS

prove the fourth quarter and FY26 annual results.

Though the stock markets have been falling, trading volumes have seen a surge and the NSE is expecting to end the year with decent numbers, which will form part of the DRHP. "The idea behind the timing of the filing and then the listing is that it will fetch the IPO an attractive valuation and pricing, and provide a lucrative

exit to investors," said a source.

In the first nine months of the current fiscal year, NSE reported a 22 per cent drop in net profit to ₹7,431 crore and a 10 per cent fall in total income to ₹13,354 crore at the consolidated level.

On a standalone basis, the net profit was down 5 per cent and total income 12 per cent.

Last month, the exchange

invited expressions of interest from selling shareholders to tender their shares in the IPO, and sources indicated that discussions are underway on the quantum of stakes being sold by each of the shareholders.

KEY SHAREHOLDERS

Top shareholders in the exchange include LIC (10.72 per cent), SBI (3.23 per cent), SBI Capital Markets (4.33 per cent), Stock Holding Corporation of India (4.44 per cent), and Temasek (4.5 per cent).

Unlisted shares of the exchange currently trade in the region of ₹1,800 apiece, with a market valuation of around ₹4.7 lakh crore. Sources indicated that the exchange could be looking at a valuation of over ₹6.5 lakh crore.

There was no response from the NSE till press time to an email sent seeking clarification.

EVERY VOTE COUNTS



RECORD TURNOUT. A voter rushes in as officials close the polling station at the Government Upper Primary School at Olarikara in Keralam's Thrissur district. In the first Assembly elections after the SIR exercise, the State recorded a high voter turnout on Thursday. It had touched 78.01 per cent at 8 pm against 76 per cent in 2021. (Report on page 7) **KK NAJEEB**

Haryana, Karnataka, Telangana are top talent magnets

Tamil Nadu, Bengal, Andhra Pradesh, Kerala, Assam in Talent Negative list, finds study

KV Kurmanath

Hyderabad

Despite all the negative talk about traffic bottlenecks in Gurugram and Bengaluru, Haryana and Karnataka topped the list of Talent Positive States (those that attract more talent than they lose) in financial year 2025-26, according to a study by Xpheno. While Telangana occupies the third position, Maharashtra, Goa and Gujarat are the only other 'talent magnet' States.

Karnataka has a positive talent balance of 74,000 employees (the difference between the talent it attracted and lost), Haryana 26,700, and it is 25,500 for Telangana. The number of 'talent positive States' is down to six in 2025-26 from nine the previous year.

All other States, includ-



KEY HUB. India remained an attractive destination for companies to set up offshore offices thanks to factors such as the speed at which they can hire talent and start operations

ing poll-bound Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Kerala, Assam and Andhra Pradesh, are in the Talent Negative list, that is, they lost more jobs than they gained.

JOB LOSSES

"They have lost jobs in the range of 9,000 to 22,000 last financial year," Kamal Karanth, Co-Founder of staffing company Xpheno, told

businessline. He was here to launch the third edition of the Talent Landscape of Telangana. He said the State had an edge over others in talent absorption.

He said India remained an attractive destination for companies to set up offshore offices. "Factors such as the speed at which they can hire talent and start operations make the country a

favourable location for global companies," he said.

RETURNING TECHIES

Karanth said the number of techies coming back to India had been growing over the last few years.

"We had almost 58,000 techies moving out of India last year. But last year was also unique in that 43,000 came back... The net loss over the last three years is coming down. In 2023, we lost 30,000 engineers, in 2024 we lost 25,000, and last year we only lost 15,000," he said.

Asked about the impact of AI on job losses, he said it required a deeper study. "Currently, much of the AI impact is just talk. Half of the internal AI experiments conducted at some firms have failed. You need a human-in-the-loop as you adapt to AI," he said.

Starlink clears security hurdle; DCC may take up Musk firm's proposal next week

S Ronendra Singh

New Delhi

India is poised to clear Starlink for commercial entry, with the Elon Musk-owned satellite broadband provider fulfilling all security requirements of law enforcement agencies (LEAs).

Government sources told businessline that the Digital Communications Commission (DCC) is expected to meet as early as next week to take up the proposal, putting the company on the cusp of formal approval after months of regulatory scrutiny.

The clearance marks a decisive step in Starlink's India entry timeline. Following the anticipated DCC approval, the proposal will move to the Union Cabinet for final sign-off, potentially within weeks, paving the way for the launch of satellite broadband ser-

vices in one of the world's fastest-growing digital markets.

GATHERING MOMENTUM

The Starlink proposal gathered momentum after senior SpaceX executives, including President and COO Gwynne Shotwell and Vice-President (Global Business) Lauren Dreyer, met Telecom Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia on April 1 to review progress on the company's India rollout plan.

Starlink's compliance process accelerated after it began equipment testing in Mumbai in October 2025, one of the final stages in India's mandatory security vetting for satellite and telecom operators.

With LEA clearances now secured, officials said the proposal is "ready for decision," placing next week's DCC meeting at the centre of the approval timeline.



Following the DCC approval, the proposal will move to the Cabinet for final sign-off

Once operational, Starlink will enter a rapidly evolving satellite broadband race, competing directly with Jio SpaceFiber, backed by Mukesh Ambani, and Eutelsat OneWeb, supported by Sunil Bharti Mittal. The entry of Starlink is expected to intensify competition and accelerate satellite-based connectivity, particularly in rural and remote regions.

SPECTRUM PRICING

However, one major issue remains unresolved — spectrum pricing. The Depart-

ment of Telecommunications and the Telecom Regulatory Authority of India remain divided over spectrum usage charges. TRAI has recommended a 4 per cent annual spectrum usage charge, while the DoT has proposed a higher 5 per cent levy and rejected subsidy proposals for user terminals, signalling a more market-driven approach.

PARTNERSHIPS

Strategic partnerships are also taking shape ahead of launch. Starlink has entered into distribution agreements with Reliance Jio Platforms and Bharti Airtel, with Jio expected to integrate satellite broadband into its network and Airtel focusing on rural deployment.

Vodafone Idea has partnered with AST SpaceMobile to roll out competing satellite-powered mobile broadband services.

QUICKLY.

Sanjay Khanna appointed
BPCL Chairman & MD



New Delhi: State-run Bharat Petroleum Corporation (BPCL) said on Thursday that the Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) has approved the posting of Sanjay Khanna as the Chairman & Managing Director (C&MD) of the company. He is currently serving as Director (Refineries). The appointment has been approved by the ACC based on the recommendation of the Search-cum-Selection Committee (SCSC), under the aegis of the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas. Khanna will assume charge, effective from the date of assumption of office, and will hold the position till his superannuation on May 31, 2029. With extensive experience in refinery operations and project execution, Khanna is expected to further strengthen BPCL's strategic focus. **OUR BUREAU**

Centre set to ease norms for small cars in CAFE-3 shake-up

DECISIVE MOVE. April 16 meet is the last major stakeholder round to seal final rules

S Ronendra Singh
New Delhi

The upcoming Corporate Average Fuel Efficiency-3 (CAFE-3) norms are likely to offer significant concessions to small cars, marking a decisive tilt in favour of entry-level and compact vehicles even as emission targets tighten sharply for large, fuel-intensive SUVs.

Sources told *businessline* that a high-level meeting at the Cabinet Secretariat this Wednesday, attended by Secretaries from the Ministry of Road Transport & Highways (MoRTH), Ministry of Power (MoP) and Ministry of Heavy Industries (MHI), paved the way for key revisions to the draft CAFE-3 framework released in September 2025.

The next decisive step comes on April 16, when the three Secretaries will jointly chair a critical meeting with industry stakeholders and original equipment manu-



CARBON POOL. Another change under consideration is the introduction of a CO₂ pooling mechanism, allowing companies to average emissions across the first three years of the regime **REUTERS**

facturers (OEMs), at the Ministry of Power.

PMO NOD “Industry bodies such as SIAM and major OEM representatives have been called to present their views before the norms are finalised,” a government source said, adding that the final recommendations will subsequently be sent to the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) for approval. Industry sources confirmed participation in the

April 16 consultations, widely seen as the last major stakeholder round before the rules are locked in. Sources added that the revised draft proposes flattening the slope in the CO₂ target calculation formula, a move that effectively eases compliance pressure on lighter, small vehicles while tightening benchmarks for heavier vehicles.

Another key consideration is the introduction of a CO₂ pooling mechanism, allowing companies to average

emissions across the first three years of the regime. Automakers missing targets in FY2027-28 could then offset shortfalls using performance in FY2028-29 and FY2029-30, with compliance assessed cumulatively at the end of the third year. The same averaging approach would apply to the final two years of the cycle.

The five-year CAFE-3 regime is scheduled to come into force from April 2027, covering FY2027-28 to FY2031-32.

With just weeks to finalise the framework, the April 16 meeting is expected to be pivotal in determining the final contours of India's next-generation fuel efficiency norms, rules that could reshape vehicle strategy across the industry.

For automakers, especially those heavily invested in compact cars, the emerging changes signal a potential strategic win, if the final round of negotiations holds.

VISUALLY.

Compiled by **Yashaswani Chauhan** | Graphic: **Visveswaran V**

India powers into nuclear Stage II

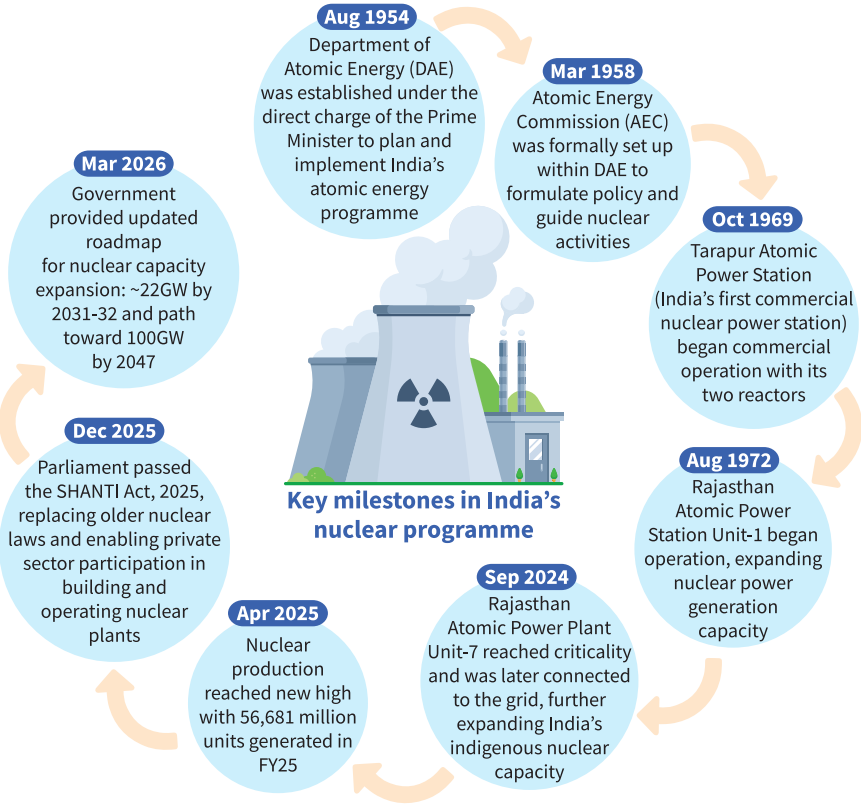
India has taken a major step in its nuclear energy journey with the Prototype Fast Breeder Reactor (PFBR) at Kalpakkam achieving “criticality” on April 6, 2026. Criticality means the reactor has started a controlled and self-sustaining nuclear chain reaction for the first time, the point at which it begins producing energy. This marks India's entry into the second stage of its long-planned three-stage nuclear programme

How the three-stage plan works

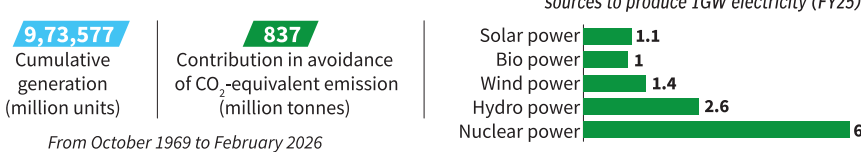
Stage I	Stage II	Stage III
Uranium is used to produce electricity and generate plutonium waste	Waste plutonium (from Stage I) is used to produce even more fuel	Finally, India plans to use its large thorium reserves to produce long-term clean energy

India's current nuclear power landscape

Contribution	~3% of total electricity generation
Installed capacity	8.78 GW
Expansion target	22.38 GW by 2031-32 with 700 MW and 1,000 MW reactors

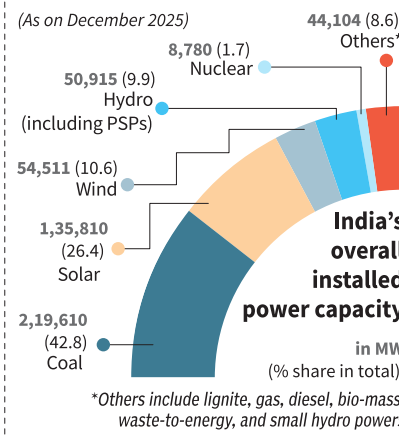


Nuclear energy's climate impact



US and China lead nuclear output, India share at 2.45%

	Nuclear power supplied (GW h)	% share of total nuclear power supplied
US	7,81,945.1	38.4
China	4,17,517.6	20.5
Japan	84,886.9	4.2
India	49,909.9	2.5
UK	37,295.2	1.8
France	3,64,390.8	17.9
Russia	2,02,104.1	9.9
Canada	81,155.6	4.0
Brazil	14,863.0	0.7



Source: PIB, Lok Sabha, NPCIL, World Nuclear Association, Power Reactor Information System

TCS Q4 results: Structural concerns remain

Hari Viswanath
bl. research bureau



From the perspective of a long-term investor, Q4 results is largely a rounding error in the midst of structural AI disruption that is upending the industry.

ANALYSIS.

On that count, the industry and company remain in the purgatory stage for now. While an optimist would like to highlight the 1 per cent beat in Q4 results versus expectations across revenue, EBIT and net income, that is unlikely to enthrone any real investor.

The pessimist would highlight how constant currency revenue growth, flattish for the quarter on a year-on-year basis, has actually declined an unprecedented 2.4 per

cent for the full year FY26. But this too does not mean much, as this was well expected given the way the FY26 had started. So no surprises or shocks either way. Gulf War 3 and its impact (while not significant for now as indicated by management), a slowing US economy, tremors in US private credit are all significant overhangs for TCS, but the company has successfully dealt with similar headwinds in the past. But this too pales in the context of uncertainty to an investor on what is going to be the long-term revenue growth rate and sustainable margin for the company as

AI disruption intensifies. Here no one has clarity, including the management. While they mentioned in the earnings call that the current cycle of AI revenue cannibalising traditional/digital revenue can play out similar to the past cycle when digital revenue cannibalised legacy revenue in the previous decade, the timeline of the current cycle is unclear. In the past cycle, it was around a 2-3 year phase during which investor outlook moved from despair to hope to optimism. While analysts and investors can make some guesstimates on timelines for the current cycle, for

now, it is more like throwing spaghetti on the wall. The current disruption is severe and uncertainty is higher than ever.

INVESTOR TAKEAWAY

The stock of TCS today trading at ₹2,590 has corrected by nearly 45 per cent from its all time high of ₹4,592, is trading at its cheapest valuation levels in the last 5 years at a trailing PE of 19 times (well below five year average valuation at 30 times), it is a quality company with a quality management. Yet, these are not sufficient balm to make the stock attractive. At *bl.portfolio*, over the last four years, via many articles on the company and the sector, we had consistently without exception recommended to investors to avoid the stock/sector given unfavourable risk-reward. With our views well valid-

ated over the years, under normal circumstances we would have turned positive at current valuations given significant price and time-wise correction, but as explained, current times are not normal. If investors check out other quality global software stocks (IT services or products), many have corrected even more and trade even cheaper. Accenture which is the global leader in IT services hit a multi-year low on Thursday and trades at a PE of 13.7 times! While business is different, but worth noting, an industry bellwether like Adobe trades at PE of 13.5 times. TCS today, might be cheap relative to its past, but not when investors realise they have options to buy global bellwethers at significantly cheaper valuations. The stock remains a wait-and-watch for now.

Hyatt looks at India acquisitions

Aneesh Phadnis
Mumbai



Hyatt Hotels is looking at acquisitions to scale up presence in India. The US-headquartered chain has 55 properties in India alongside another 91 in pipeline.

SUPER BULLISH

Hyatt is considering both organic and inorganic growth models as it aspires to grow five-fold in the next five years.

“We are super bullish about India. Indians are looking at luxury travel and differentiated experiences. We do that really well,” said Vikas Chawla, who recently took over as Hyatt's President for India and South West

Asia. Stephen Ho, President, Greater China & Growth, Asia Pacific at Hyatt, said the conflict in West Asia has not curbed developer interest in the hotel business in India. “I have not seen such a high level of confidence among owners elsewhere,” he said. International chains including Hyatt largely rely on

management contracts for expansion. However Hyatt has taken the inorganic route in other countries in the region. In Japan, Hyatt has invested in a real estate fund for development of Japanese style inns. Earlier this year, Hyatt signed a strategic agreement with a local firm to bring six Wink brand hotels under its fold.

“In 2026, we will open five hotels in India including our first Destination by Hyatt in Jaipur. This will be our tenth brand in India,” said David Udell, President, Asia Pacific.

The chain plans to strengthen presence in Mumbai, Bengaluru, New Delhi and Hyderabad and expand into high growth destinations.

Surging raw material costs hit PVC, packaging hard

Our Bureau
Mumbai



A sharp surge in crude oil prices triggered by the West Asia conflict has sent shockwaves through the PVC industry, driving raw material costs up by 60 per cent and causing acute shortages. This is forcing manufacturers to curb production and pass on price increases to consumers.

Prices of polymers, a key raw material derived from crude oil refining, have jumped substantially.

Anil Jain, Vice-Chairman & CEO, Jain Irrigation Systems, said the West Asia war led to a sharp increase in raw material prices, which rose by about 60 per cent — from

₹70 to ₹115 a kg. “India is still dependent on the world for PVC, but we have huge potential. Our utilisation remains low, and PVC offers extraordinary growth opportunities in the future,” he said on the sidelines of global summit and exhibition Vinyl India 2026 inauguration on Thursday.

PVC is at the heart of water and food security, and the government should work towards building a stable and integrated PVC value chain to overcome global geopolitical disruptions and ensure long-term price stability, he said.

GROWING MARKET

PVC market is currently estimated at about 4.3 million tonnes per annum and has been growing at 6-8 per cent annually. It is estimated to hit ₹50,000 crore by 2030 from the current level of ₹35,000 crore.

MP Taparia, Chairman & Managing Director, Supreme Industries, said PVC has a huge opportunity driven by India's growing economy and rising demand across

housing, agriculture, healthcare, and infrastructure. The shortage of HDPE has also taken a toll on scores of other sectors including FMCG, cement, agrochemical and fertilizer industry, dependent on it for packaging.

Pitamber Lal Sharma, Shri Navkar Agropack, said HDPE polymer prices had surged from ₹98 a kg to about ₹163 a kg in last few months due to disruption in global supply chains.

The cost of master batches has increased from about ₹220 to ₹340 per kg. This sharp rise in raw material prices has led to nearly 70 per cent increase in the production cost of HDPE bottles, he said.

Durgesh Agarwal, Central India Polysack, said the pack-

aging industry's key inputs such as PP woven fabric, BOPP film, HDPE, and PP laminates have risen 60-80 per cent in recent weeks.

The sudden surge in costs of these materials used in manufacturing fertilizer bags and rice exports will put significant pressure on manufacturers and the overall supply chain, he added.

Rajib Chakraborty, National President, Soluble Fertiliser Industry Association, said war-driven disruptions are significantly impacting fertiliser packaging costs which account for 4-10 per cent of end product cost.

In contrast, high-value fertilisers remain relatively insulated, with packaging contributing only 2-4 per cent of costs, he added.

JBM Auto eyes \$500 m fundraise to expand e-bus biz

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

JBM Auto is exploring a potential \$500 million fundraise to support its expanding electric mobility business, as it looks to execute and scale an order book of nearly 10,000 electric buses, sources said.

The company has already raised over \$250 million for its electric mobility platform, including about \$100



Our order book is close to 10,000 buses; we expect to double that over the next 1-2 years

NISHANT ARYA
Vice-Chairman, JBM Group



million in FY26, and is expected to tap additional capital as deployments accelerate.

The fundraise comes amid a broader surge in investments in India's electric bus ecosystem. JBM Auto secured around \$100 million from the International Finance Corporation (IFC), while GreenCell Mobility raised nearly \$89 million from IFC, British International Investment, and Tata

Capital. Private equity major KKR has also committed about \$310 million to back PMI Electro Mobility and related platforms.

10,000 BUSES

JBM's planned fundraise is aimed at executing its current order book while expanding its pipeline. “Our current order book is close to 10,000 buses, and we expect to at least double that over the next one to two years,”

said Nishant Arya, Vice-Chairman, JBM Group, declining to comment on the fundraise. The company registered over 1,200 electric buses in FY26, capturing around 24 per cent market share and emerging as India's largest electric bus manufacturer by volume.

The market is transitioning from pilot projects to scaled deployments, with demand expanding beyond State transport undertakings (STUs) into intercity, private fleet, and institutional segments such as school and staff mobility. “Intercity operators and new players are also coming in,” Arya said.

To support this growth, JBM operates one of the world's largest integrated electric bus manufacturing facilities outside China, with an annual capacity of 20,000 units.

Mercedes to hike prices again as luxe market splits

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai



Mercedes-Benz India is set to raise prices of luxury cars by a further 2-4 per cent in the second quarter of 2026, after already implementing a 4 per cent hike over the last couple of months as geopolitical disruptions, freight costs and currency pressures push up input expenses.

“Another 2-4 per cent increase is on the cards,” Managing Director and CEO Santosh Iyer said, citing a 15-20 per cent cost burden.

Automakers are opting for staggered increases rather than passing on the full impact at once. “We cannot pass on the full increase at once. There would be a shock to the market,” Iyer said.

Currency depreciation has further added to cost

pressures, impacting vehicle allocations, forcing companies to balance pricing with demand.

Chasing value, not volume, India's largest luxury carmaker sharpens its focus on higher-end vehicles, highlighting a growing divergence in the market. Mercedes is leaning into pricing power and exclusivity, while rivals such as BMW are pursuing broader, volume-led

growth. Mercedes-Benz India posted record sales of 19,363 units in FY26, with its top-end portfolio, S-Class, Maybach, AMG and EQS, accounting for 27 per cent of volumes, or over 5,200 units, growing 16 per cent.

Momentum has continued into 2026, with first-quarter sales rising 7 per cent to 5,131 units, led by a 25 per cent jump in top-end vehicles. In contrast, the entry luxury segment declined 18 per cent, reflecting a deliberate shift away from price-led volumes.

Strong demand for ultra-luxury models such as the AMG G63 and Maybach S-Class, with waiting periods stretching up to a year, is giving Mercedes room to push through price increases.

BMW BETS ON SCALE

BMW India is driving a wider

play across segments. It sold 18,001 cars in 2025 and reported 17 per cent growth on-year in the March quarter.

Electric vehicles are central to its strategy. One in four BMW cars sold in Q1 was electric at 1,185 units, up 83 per cent on-year, giving it over 70 per cent share of the luxury EV market. “We are cognisant of what we are missing out in entry-level luxury EVs,” Iyer said.

Mercedes is looking to respond with the launch of the CLA Electric at ₹55-60 lakh, built on the new MMA platform and premium than the iX1. The contrast is increasingly clear: BMW's iX1 serves as an accessible entry point into luxury EVs, while Mercedes continues to prioritise higher range, larger batteries and premium positioning.

QUICKLY.

Russia offers sanctioned LNG to Asia at 40% cut



Bengaluru: Russia is seeking to lure South Asian nations to buy shipments from its U.S.-sanctioned facilities with large discounts, leveraging a global natural gas supply crunch, *Bloomberg News* said on Thursday, citing people familiar with the matter. The shipments were being offered last week at a discount of 40% to spot prices via little-known intermediary companies based in China and Russia, it said. **REUTERS**

India grants waivers to 2 cargoes from Iran

New Delhi: With a view to speeding delivery of energy supplies from the Gulf, India recently granted waivers to allow two Iranian cargoes aboard an older tanker and another under international sanctions to enter its ports, two officials familiar with the matter said. India is facing its worst gas crisis in decades, with the government rationing supplies to industry to ensure households are supplied with the cooking gas. **REUTERS**

Top Ministers line up visits to West Asia, post ceasefire

KEY SUPPLIER. Exports from the region accounted for 92% of India’s LPG supply in 2025

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

With the declaration of ceasefire in West Asia, India moved to secure its energy interests with two Indian Ministers visiting top suppliers of liquefied natural gas (LNG) and liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) in the Middle East Gulf (MEG) region.

Beginning Thursday, Union Minister for Petroleum and Natural Gas Hardeep Singh Puri is on a two-day visit to Qatar, which is India’s largest supplier of LNG and LPG, accounting for around 47 per cent and 20 per cent respectively.

This is followed by a two-day visit of External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar to the UAE, beginning Saturday. The Arab nation is India’s fifth-largest crude oil supplier and among top three countries for LNG and LPG. Besides, India and the UAE have already inked a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA).

Ministry of External Affairs Spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said India continues to closely monitor develop-



UPCOMING TRIPS. Union Minister for Petroleum and Natural Gas Hardeep Singh Puri is on a two-day visit to Qatar, which is India’s largest supplier of LNG and LPG

ments in West Asia and remains engaged with countries in the region.

PRESSURE POINT

“External Affairs Minister will pay an official visit to the UAE from April 11-12. During the visit, he will meet the leadership of the UAE to review bilateral cooperation and further strengthen the India-UAE Comprehensive Strategic Partnership. India is also reaching out to other countries in the region through high-level engagements. The Minister of Petroleum & Natural Gas is undertaking an official visit to Qatar on April 9-10,” he added.

The visits assume importance as India faces stiff challenges in securing LPG supplies. MEG region’s LPG exports, largely consisting of evenly-split cargoes, supplied 92 per cent of India’s LPG at roughly 720,000 barrels per day (b/d) in 2025, as per Vortexa.

Global real-time data and analytics provider Kpler recently pointed out that India remains materially exposed to West Asia, with a significant share of its LNG imports tied to long-term contracts with QatarEnergy.

A top official explained that LPG is a key “pressure point” for India and will be part of discussions during

these visits. LNG is another “area of concern” as QatarEnergy’s LNG production is severely hit.

LPG SOURCES

While India has 41 sources for procuring crude oil and 30 sources for LNG imports, it has just 15 sources available for LPG with major supplies being in MEG and the US.

For instance, India’s monthly LPG imports fell from roughly 2 million tonnes (mt) in February 2026 to a little over 1.10 mt last month, the official explained.

India has been frantically trying to secure additional LPG supplies from the US, Russia, Iran, Australia, and the UAE, among others.

Since February 28, several LPG facilities have halted operations such as the UAE’s Al Ruwais Industrial Complex, Qatari Pearl GTL plant in Ras Laffan, and Kuwaiti gas processing facility at the Mina Al-Ahmadi refinery. Besides, there were pre-conflict issues at Saudi Arabia’s Juaymah terminal in Ras Tanura, Anna Zhminko, Associate Market Analyst at Vortexa, recently said.

‘India now seen as safe anchor, offers stability and prospects’

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

“India is a safe anchor” amid global uncertainty, Shaktikanta Das, Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister, said here on Thursday while suggesting a seven-point agenda for the corporate sector.

“India is now seen as a safe anchor because it offers stability, predictability and prospects of long-term growth at a time when much of the world is marked by conflict, volatility and policy uncertainty,” Das said, addressing the AIMA National Leadership Conclave.

RESILIENT FRONT

The former RBI Governor noted that the global economy continues to face an “unsettled and charged environment” marked by geopolitical fragmentation, supply chain disruptions and uneven growth, with risks “decisively skewed to the downside”.

Against this backdrop, Das highlighted India’s strong economic performance, stating that real GDP growth stood at 7.6 per cent in FY26, with an average growth of 7.8 per cent over the past five years. “India’s resilience does not alone explain the full story. India did not just endure the period of turbu-



OPTIMISTIC OUTLOOK. Shaktikanta Das, Principal Secretary to the Prime Minister, speaking at the ‘National Leadership Conclave’, marking AIMA’s Platinum Jubilee in New Delhi **PTI**

lence. It transformed through it,” he said.

Das also noted that several factors underpin this resilience, including macroeconomic stability, policy consistency, infrastructure-led development and strong domestic demand.

The top official emphasised the importance of inflation control, describing it as critical for economic stability. “Inflation has often been described as a tax on the poor. A low inflation would mean increasing the spending power of the consumer,” Das said.

GROWTH DRIVERS

Highlighting India’s policy response during crises, he said the country adopted a calibrated approach. “Fiscal and monetary expansion were followed by a timely rollback, thus froth was not

allowed to accumulate or overrun the system”. Looking ahead, Das said India’s growth drivers, ranging from demographic advantage and rising consumption to infrastructure push and digital public infrastructure, are structural and durable.

Das presented seven suggestions for Indian businesses.

“At moments like these, when the whole world is experiencing unprecedented volatility, it would be appropriate for Indian industry and business to build organisational resilience, strengthen balance sheets, build new supply chains, protect jobs, reskill the available manpower, diversify into new markets (especially the exporters) and invest strategically for future readiness and for capitalising on new opportunities,” he said.

As India & US look to revive trade deal talks, delegation to visit Washington this month

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

In a move that may put bilateral trade talks back on track, US Ambassador to India Sergio Goro on Thursday said a high-level Indian delegation will visit Washington later this month, signalling a renewed push to finalise the proposed interim trade deal.

The development comes after negotiations slowed amid uncertainty over US tariff measures after the US Supreme Court invalidated the ‘reciprocal tariffs’.

“The United States and India have previously agreed to a trade deal, and we look forward to welcoming an Indian delegation to Washington later this month,” Goro said in a post on X, following his meeting with US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer.

The visit will also provide India an opportunity to raise concerns over two ongoing Section 301 investigations launched by the US Trade Representative: one related to excess manufacturing capacity and the other to



IN SLOW LANE. The development comes after negotiations slowed amid uncertainty over US tariff measures after the US Supreme Court invalidated the ‘reciprocal tariffs’

forced labour, which could potentially lead to more tariffs.

DETAILS UNCLEAR

Sources in the Indian government confirmed the delegation visit, but said it was still at a planning stage. “The details of the visit of the Indian trade delegation to Washington are being worked out,” the source said.

The two nations announced a preliminary bilateral trade deal framework on February 2, 2026, but it did not get formalised or signed

as the US Supreme Court gave its judgment on February 20 invalidating the reciprocal tariff regime.

The US has indicated that it considers the framework deal, under which India agreed to eliminate or sharply reduce tariffs for most industrial goods and also lower duties on a wide range of US agricultural and food products, as good as done.

BETTER BARGAIN

But India wants more tariff concessions so that it main-

tains its advantage over competing countries such as Bangladesh and Vietnam, sources said.

“In the framework deal, Washington offered to bring down reciprocal tariffs on India to 18 per cent (from 25 per cent), which was slightly lower than those on competing countries. But now that reciprocal tariffs are gone and all countries face a uniform short-term tariff of 10 per cent, India’s tariff concessions under the deal must put it at an advantage over the others,” the source explained. Otherwise, the trade deal will not make sense.

New Delhi is also likely to draw attention to the ongoing Section 301 probes, involving India among other countries, as it could potentially negate tariff advantages of the trade pact.

Separately, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misra is on a three-day visit to Washington this week to engage senior US officials on trade, defence and global developments, amid ongoing trade investigations, fluid tariff measures and a volatile security situation in West Asia.

India mulls creating 30-day LPG reserve

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

The government is contemplating establishing 30 days of strategic reserves for liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), a move that marks a realisation that building such storage facilities (an initiative that had been overlooked until now) is no longer optional following the supply disruptions caused by the West Asia crisis.

Sources said that the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas and oil marketing companies (OMCs) have been deliberating establishment of caverns for storing LPG, on the lines of two caverns with a cumulative capacity of 1.4 lakh tonnes — which can meet roughly 1.5 days of the country’s requirements. India consumes roughly 80,000 tonnes of LPG per day.

“OMCs have been working for some time on plans for having more caverns or sites to store LPG. The present war has severely impacted India’s imports. Consequently, they are now moving aggressively on this as a medium-to-long term strategy for locating possible



READY FOR USE. India has two caverns — an 80,000-tonne rock cavern in Mangaluru and a 60,000-tonne cavern in Visakhapatnam **CV SUBRAHMANYAM**

sites and creating storage in caverns like in Mangaluru and Visakhapatnam,” said one of the sources.

The matter was also reportedly discussed in the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO). Storage for crude oil and LPG are now priority, the source added.

CURRENT CAPACITY

India already has two caverns to store the critical commodity, which is the main cooking medium for over 33 crore consumers. State-run Hindustan Petroleum Corporation (HPCL) has an 80,000 tonnes under-

ground LPG rock cavern in Mangaluru. Similarly, South Asia LPG — a JV of HPCL and TotalEnergies Marketing Holdings India — has a 60,000-tonne cavern in Visakhapatnam.

Small countries such as Japan and South Korea, which depend mostly on imports for energy consumption, already have huge strategic/commercial storages for crude oil, LNG and LPG totalling about 250 days and 200 days respectively, with a minimum of 50-60 days storage for the key cooking and heating medium.

Globally, there are more

than 80 LPG storage caverns. Underground caverns are among the safest options to store the commodity. As a pressurised propane-butane mix, LPG requires costly high-pressure or cryogenic facilities.

PUSHED TO THE BRINK

A senior official pointed out that the push to have more storage is getting priority now due to the “current crisis”.

“The government’s objective now, more than ever, is to establish storages. The present hostilities have made it quite clear that large consuming nations today have to have storages. This is pertinent not just from the perspective of energy security, but also for strategic autonomy to some extent to deal with frequent weaponisation of such resources,” the official explained.

India imports 60 per cent of its demand for the key cooking fuel.

India consumed more than 33 million tonnes (mt) of LPG in FY25, of which roughly 20.67 mt was imported. Around 90 per cent of this is imported from West Asia transiting the Strait of Hormuz.

‘Factor in adverse cases while framing policies’

Rishi Ranjan Kala
New Delhi

Neeraj Mittal, Secretary, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, on Thursday emphasised that the key lesson for India — the world’s third-largest importer of hydrocarbons — is to factor in adverse situations, such as those arising from the West Asia conflict, while planning country-wide infrastructure for energy commodities.

Speaking at a conference on energy security, Mittal assured that India’s LPG supply situation is normal with vessels continuing to arrive through the Strait of Hormuz (SoH) despite an escalation in hostilities.

“It’s only when we are faced with adversity we can actually see the chinks in our armour. I think this conference is timed with having seen 39 days of adversity,” said the Secretary.

EVERYTHING AT STAKE

Of the 33 million tonnes (mt) of LPG that India consumed in FY25, 20.67 per cent is imported, with almost 90 per cent of the imports transiting the SoH. Post February 28, India’s LPG imports from West Asia



Neeraj Mittal, Secretary, Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas **BUJOY GHOSH**

turned into a trickle, compounding problems for the government and over 33 crore households.

Mittal added, “West Asia and the Gulf crisis have shown that what we develop national infrastructure and when things are not as bad as they could be, we forget to plan for adversities. If you look at our energy dependency, world’s energy dependence, and the SoH, it is roughly 20 per cent, but our’s in all three (crude, LNG and LPG) is more than that.”

India sources crude oil from 41 countries, natural gas from 30 countries, and LPG from 15 countries. These factors must be considered while framing future energy security policies, including setting up related ecosystem and infrastructure, he added.

DGS advisory for direct pass-through of port concessions to exporters

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

In response to the escalating geopolitical tensions in West Asia, the Directorate General of Shipping (DGS) has issued a comprehensive advisory aimed at safeguarding maritime trade and ensuring operational continuity.

On March 6, the Ministry of Port, Shipping and Waterways issued a standard operating procedure for major ports to mitigate the impact of the West Asia crisis. However, sources said various concessions were delayed in the last one month.

The DGS advisory issued on Wednesday follows concerns that concessions granted by port authorities — detention charges, ground rent and reefer plug-in fees — are not being uniformly passed on to exporters.

RELIEF DELAYED

According to the DGS, terminal operators at various ports are currently billing non-vessel operating common carriers (NVOCCs), which are freight forwarders providing ocean transportation under their own House Bill of Lading without owning vessels.



These operators later pass on concessional benefits through reimbursement mechanisms, delaying relief. The DGS has mandated that all concessions must be transparently passed on to stakeholders, including freight forwarders and NVOCCs, who must in turn reflect the benefits to exporters.

The practice of routing such adjustments through reimbursements or post-facto claims has been ordered to cease immediately.

The advisory further places responsibility on port authorities to monitor compliance at the terminal level, ensuring that the intended

beneficiaries receive the concessions without delay.

The DGS also urged shipping lines to reflect any revisions in war risk premiums within freight charges.

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This notice is published pursuant to the provisions of the Investor Education and Protection Fund Authority (Accounting, Audit, Transfer and Refund) Rules, 2016 (“the Rules”) notified by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs.

The rules inter-alia, contain provisions for transfer of all shares in respect of which dividend has not been claimed by the shareholders for seven immediate preceding consecutive years or more in the name of Investor Education and Protection Fund (IEPF) Suspense Account.

Complying with the requirements set out in the rules, all shares in respect of which Fourth Interim Dividend for the financial year 2018-19 is due for transfer and the Company has simultaneously communicated to the concerned shareholders individually whose shares are liable to be transferred to IEPF Suspense Account under the said Rules for taking appropriate action(s) at their latest available address.

The Company has also uploaded the details of such shareholders and shares due for transfer to the IEPF suspense account on its website at www. Jockey.in. Shareholders are requested to refer investors section of the website to verify the details of unencashed dividends and the shares liable to be transferred to the IEPF suspense account.

In case the Company does not receive any communication from the concerned shareholders on or before June 25, 2026, Shareholders may note that both the unclaimed dividend and corresponding shares transferred to IEPF Authority/Suspense Account including all benefits accruing on such shares, if any, can be claimed back by them from IEPF Authority after following the procedure prescribed by the Rules.

In case of any enquiries, please contact the Company or the Registrar and Share Transfer Agent Link Intime India Private Limited at their following address/ email/ telephone number.

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Place: Bengaluru
Date: 1 April 2026

For Page Industries Limited
Murugesh C.
Company Secretary
ACS:21787

Wait and watch

MPC’s pause valid, amidst global headwinds

In a world where uncertainty is the only certainty, and with the ceasefire looking somewhat shaky, the Monetary Policy Committee got its decision and tonality right. Its decision on Wednesday to keep rates unchanged was accompanied by a matter-of-fact assessment of the prevailing risks. The MPC’s stocktaking comes on the heels of the Finance Ministry projecting various scenarios of growth, inflation, current account deficit and fiscal deficits, for different levels of global crude prices.



Indeed, by keeping rates unchanged, the MPC has rightly sought to meet the dual goal of containing inflation without hurting growth. It was just as well that Reserve Bank of India Governor Sanjay Malhotra’s speech was sober and realistic, rather than sanguine or gloomy with respect to the domestic economy ; he did, however, try to talk up the external account at a time of fickle flows. The MPC expects CPI inflation to be 20 basis points higher in the second quarter of FY27, compared to the projections made in the February policy, and the third quarter CPI at 5.2 per cent due to the disruptions caused by the war. There is an upside risk to these numbers if the kharif output is impacted due to poor monsoon — something that MPC does not appear to acknowledge. But a rate hike is unlikely to rein in inflation caused by supply disruption. It would hurt growth, which has been pegged 10 and 30 basis points lower for the first and second quarters of FY27 respectively by the MPC. For full year FY27, growth is projected at 6.9 per cent, 60 basis points below the growth of 7.6 per cent for FY26. Indeed, the Governor accepts the possibility of a supply shock crimping demand.

The relief provided to banks to improve their capital availability will help them address any additional stress in their loan book due to the war. The proposal to de-link the inclusion of quarterly profits in the CRAR (capital to risk weighted assets ratio) from the deviation observed in non-performing assets in previous quarters, will enable banks to improve their capital ratio and leverage. The other proposal to dispense with investment fluctuation reserve is also a right move as most banks are already recognising the investment gains or losses in their accounts on account of higher market rates.

The RBI has desisted from announcing overt steps to support the rupee, which has been among the worst performing Asian currencies — and rightly so. The move to limit net open forex position of banks in onshore markets from April 10 has resulted in the rupee halting its slide and strengthening over 2 per cent from its all-time low. With foreign portfolio investors continuing to be net sellers in equity and bond markets and remittances from West Asia at risk, the external account could face further pressure in the days ahead, if the war continues. The RBI would have to be data driven and nimble with its options, in times when little can be anticipated — on output, exports, remittances and capital flows.

OTHER VOICES.

The Guardian

A devastating war has only losers

Both the US and Iran claimed victory on Wednesday morning. Both were lying. The two-week ceasefire announced by Donald Trump the night before is not the triumph that he declared. It may not be an end to the war, as welcome as the pause is, or even last the fortnight. Mr Trump said that Iran has gone through regime change. It has not. If anything, less experienced, less readable but more headline figures are now in charge. He said that the strait of Hormuz would be open; Iran said that ships would pass through with permission, and at a price. By Wednesday evening, Iranian state media said that the strait was closed after Israel unleashed a brutal assault on Lebanon: about 100 strikes in 10 minutes. Iran had insisted that Lebanon was part of the deal, while Mr Trump disagreed. This conflict has killed thousands, including children, while the aggressors have openly boasted of their intent to commit war crimes. LONDON, APRIL 8

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

EUROPE

Trump Declares Premature Victory in Iran

Did the war with Iran that began with a roar end with a whimper? That’s the way it looks in the cold light of Wednesday after President Trump’s announcement late Tuesday of a two-week cease-fire. Mr. Trump achieved some of his war aims, but the Iranian regime remains a threat in the Strait of Hormuz and the job is far from finished, despite what he promised last week. Mr. Trump and Vice President JD Vance said the cease-fire is conditioned on Iran’s striking a deal, but it sure sounds like the President wants the war over. “A big day for World Peace! Iran wants it to happen, they’ve had enough! Likewise, so has everyone else!” he posted on Truth Social early Wednesday. NEW YORK, APRIL 8



Large corporates and the sustainability transition of MSMEs

GREEN PATH. A corporate-backed green MSME guarantee facility will go a long way in achieving India’s climate goals



SREELAKSHMI HARIHARAN
MUKUND RAJAN

India’s updated Nationally Determined Contribution (NDC) to cut emissions intensity by 47 per cent below 2005 levels will not be tested in the boardrooms of large corporates alone.

Consider this — India’s Micro, Small and Medium Enterprise (MSME) ecosystem sits at the centre of the country’s economic development. Over 74 million MSMEs collectively contribute more than 30 per cent of India’s GDP. These MSMEs are also responsible for roughly 10-15 per cent of industrial emissions and 25 per cent of industrial energy consumption. With their energy demands expected to increase by 50 per cent by 2030, they become an integral part of any national climate and sustainability strategy.

However, despite their central role, MSMEs receive only a small fraction of green finance flows. The challenge really lies in the absence of financing structures suited to MSME realities. Too many lenders view sustainability-focused investments in and by MSMEs as too risky due to uncertain payback timelines, limited collateral and thin credit histories.

As a result, the sector that represents one of the largest opportunities for industrial decarbonisation and greening of the economy, remains the least served by green finance. A simple but powerful financial innovation such as a corporate-backed green guarantee instrument can help unlock the capital needed for the sustainability transition of MSMEs.

STRUCTURAL FINANCING

There is a structural advantage that already exists within India’s industrial ecosystem. Large corporates depend heavily on MSME suppliers. These relationships create natural financial linkages that can be leveraged to unlock capital.

Take the example of the automotive sector. Companies such as Tata Motors and Maruti Suzuki rely on extensive networks of suppliers. These OEMs can leverage long-term contracts and payment histories to nudge their suppliers to modernise processes, electrify furnaces and adopt more energy-efficient technologies to remain on approved vendor lists.

A similar dynamic exists in the consumer goods sector. Companies such as Hindustan Unilever and ITC source from hundreds of packaging manufacturers and agri-processing units. Transitioning these suppliers to recycled packaging, solar-powered operations or cleaner processing technologies is essential for meeting their corporate sustainability commitments.

Fleet electrification for e-commerce and quick commerce platforms such as Amazon, Zomato and Blinkit which depend on thousands of small logistics operators and delivery franchises represents yet another opportunity. In all these cases, large corporates at

A large corporate can establish a small guarantee reserve, covering say, 1-2 per cent of a loan pool, which serves as a first-loss or partial credit guarantee for sustainability loans extended to its suppliers

the top of the pyramid possess three assets that MSMEs lack: fairly strong creditworthiness, detailed operational data on supplier performance, and a direct commercial interest in ensuring suppliers remain competitive and compliant with quality and regulatory requirements.

GREEN BACKED GUARANTEE

These supply chain relationships can form the foundation of a new financing instrument — a corporate-backed green MSME guarantee facility.

Under such a structure, a large corporate establishes a small guarantee reserve, covering say, 1-2 per cent of a loan pool, which serves as a first-loss or partial credit guarantee for sustainability loans extended to its suppliers. Banks, NBFCs or development finance institutions can then issue green loans to eligible MSME suppliers, with the proceeds ring-fenced for verified sustainability investments such as rooftop solar installations, energy-efficient machinery upgrades, EV fleet conversions, water recycling systems, effluent treatment plants, and the like. The repayment can be structured against future purchase orders or trade receivables from the anchor corporate, significantly reducing default risk.

There are many interesting ways in which such an instrument can be structured and administered, and aspects of such a scheme are already embedded in the RBI promoted Trade Receivables Discounting System (TReDS).

For instance, a corporate and its banker such as an SBI, HDFC Bank or ICICI Bank could enter into a bilateral arrangement for a supply chain loan facility covering a defined pool of suppliers. Or, the corporate could issue sustainability-linked supply chain bond

with interest rates linked to emission reductions across the supplier network. Blended finance structures could also be created, where development finance institutions such as SIDBI or Nabard participate alongside commercial lenders, spreading risk across multiple layers of capital.

Even conservative adoption could unlock substantial capital. Assuming MSMEs require on an average around ₹1.5 crore in sustainability investments, a large corporate with say 500 key suppliers could generate a loan pool of ₹750 crore, requiring up to only ₹15 crore for a guarantee reserve.

VIRTUOUS CIRCLE

Such a financing model would create benefits across the ecosystem.

For MSMEs, it would unlock access to affordable long-term capital. For corporates, supporting suppliers in their sustainability transition would improve ESG performance metrics, reduce risk, enhance credibility with global investors and strengthen supply chain resilience. Large corporates, in particular, could burnish their image as socially responsible actors.

Banks and financial institutions would gain access to a new, scalable lending opportunity with significantly reduced credit risk due to corporate guarantees and stable supplier relationships.

India’s MSME sector is not the problem in the sustainability transition. It is the opportunity. Corporate-backed green guarantee instruments can become the bridge between climate ambition and industrial reality — mobilising large pools of capital through a simple, low-risk financial innovation that can be deployed today.

Hariharan is Managing Director; Rajan is Chairperson, ECube Investment Advisors

RBI plumps for caution amidst uncertainty

The status quo on rates was on expected lines, given the geopolitical turbulence and its economic impact

Aditi Nayar

The Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) presciently stuck to the status quo on policy rates and stance in its first meeting for FY27, as heightened geopolitical uncertainty clouded visibility around India’s macroeconomic outcomes. The Committee expectedly resorted to cautious commentary, stressing upside and downside risks to the outlook for inflation and growth, respectively, in contrast with typical statements where risks are balanced around both.

While a temporary ceasefire has been announced between the US and Iran, the situation in West Asia remains unnervingly volatile. Even if hindsight shows that the crisis has ended, energy prices are unlikely to rapidly revert to pre-conflict levels immediately, with the reports of damage to energy infrastructure, which may also continue to constrain availability. With persisting uncertainty on all these factors, projecting macroeconomic outcomes precisely for India for FY27 is a challenging task.

Assuming an average Brent price of \$85/barrel in FY27 and a normal monsoon, the MPC has estimated India’s CPI inflation and GDP growth at 4.6 per cent and 6.9 per cent, respectively, in the fiscal. This marks a

worsening relative to FY26, when CPI inflation is estimated to have averaged at a much more sedate 2.1 per cent and GDP growth is forecast at a healthy 7.5 per cent, as per ICRA’s projections. Moderating growth along with hardening inflation complicates policy choices for the central bank.

The Committee’s CPI inflation projection exceeds our forecast of 4.3 per cent for the fiscal, even as we broadly concur with the core CPI estimate of 4.4 per cent for FY2027. However, a potential El Nino would hold negative implications on agriculture output and food prices, even as the current ample reservoir storage provides some near-term respite.

GROWTH OUTLOOK SANGUINE

On the GDP front, the MPC’s growth forecast is more sanguine than our estimate of 6.5 per cent for the fiscal. Notwithstanding the favourable base, the MPC’s estimate for GDP growth in Q1 FY27, at 6.8 per cent, seems particularly strong, given that the adverse impact of the crisis is likely to be concentrated in this quarter.

Given the current flux, these projections are admittedly subject to large changes. For instance, an average oil price that is \$20 higher than our baseline estimate of \$85/barrel (along with constrained energy availability) could worsen GDP growth to sub-6 per



MPC. On watchful mode REUTERS

cent. Concurrently, it would raise CPI inflation by at least 30-40 bps, even if we assume limited pass-through to fuel prices, while adversely impacting the government’s fiscal metrics. Further, it would widen the current account deficit (CAD)-to-GDP ratio by 70 bps in the fiscal.

Given the extent of the volatility that the global economy has witnessed between the February 2026 and April 2026 MPC reviews, monetary policy may need to continue to adopt a cautious and wait-and-watch approach in the near term. Nevertheless, given the expected uptick in inflation, and the sizeable upside risks to the inflation trajectory, another rate cut can certainly be ruled out for the current easing cycle.

In fact, the next move is likely to be a hike, although the timing of the same remains quite uncertain at present, and would depend on geopolitical

developments and energy price movements, and their transmission to India’s growth-inflation dynamics.

YIELD SWINGS

Following the ceasefire, the yields on the benchmark 10-year Government of India security (G-sec) has corrected sharply to 6.92 per cent intraday, after having crossed 20-month high of 7.1 per cent in early-April 2026. Yet, the 10-year yield remains well above the 6.66 per cent seen at end-February 2026, before the crisis began.

The risks of a fiscal slippage against the budgeted 4.3 per cent of GDP for FY2027 remain, owing to lower excise duty and corporate tax collections, and dividend payouts by Oil Marketing Companies (OMCs), as well as a higher subsidy burden, despite some buffer provided by the Economic Stabilisation Fund (ESF), which would continue to put pressure on yields.

Likewise, while the INR has appreciated from the recent all-time low, downside risks to the USD/INR pair persist, as higher oil prices could manifest into a worsening in the balance of payments position. Tightening financial conditions could hurt growth, in addition to high energy prices, even if policy rates remain unchanged.

The writer is Chief Economist, Head- Research & Outreach, ICRA

LETTERS TO EDITOR

Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to 'Letters to the Editor', The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Fragile peace

This refers to the Editorial 'Cease and desist' (April 9). The announcement of ceasefire triggered few positive reactions. Brent crude oil going southward and stock market indices going up. Iran's strong hold on the Hormuz Strait and insisting on payment of \$2million for every ship towards its safe passage would aggravate the situation. This needs to be negotiated first and normalcy in ship movement restored. Pakistan is in limelight now for taking the lead in mediating between the warring sides. This war, which no one wanted, has wreaked economic havoc and has thrown people's lives out of gear.

Let saner counsel prevail at least hereafter.

RV Baskaran
Pune

Welcome pause

This refers to the Editorial 'Cease and desist', (April 9). After weeks of escalation and uncertainty, even a pause in hostilities offers much-needed relief — both for the people affected and the global economy. This ceasefire, though fragile, should at least endure long enough to create a pathway toward a formal end to the conflict. Though this is what the international community would hope for, the outcome remains uncertain.

Wars of this nature seldom produce clear winners, leaving behind deep economic and geopolitical scars. Supply chains have been disrupted, commodity markets unsettled, and investor confidence shaken. While a full return to pre-war stability is unlikely, the ceasefire presents an opportunity for gradual stabilisation and recovery.

N Sadhasiva Reddy
Bangaluru

An apt cartoon

This refers to the cartoon by Ravikanth (April 9). Ravikanth has captured the essential injustice of the situation with an admirable economy. Both the US and Iran claim

to have fought a war. While the US and Israel attacked Iran, the global economy paid its price. Supply disruptions, elevated crude, tightened liquidity — none of these were on any ballot. The cartoon is funny, but the underlying point is sobering.

K Sakunthala
Coimbatore

PM communicates

This refers to the article 'Together, Let Us Empower Our Nari Shakti' (April 9). Prime Minister Modi's decision to write directly for newspapers on women's reservation marks a meaningful shift in executive communication.

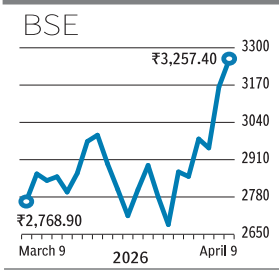
Mann ki Baat reaches millions, but a signed article in print invites scrutiny and has major significance. When significant Bills are introduced, Parliamentary uproar routinely drowns out substance, leaving ordinary citizens with fragments. Writing directly bypasses that noise. The announcement that Parliament convenes on April 16 converts intent into commitment. If this becomes regular practice — explaining legislation through print before political theatre takes over — it would be a genuinely welcome addition to democratic communication.

A Myilsami
Coimbatore



QUICKLY.

BSE gets nod to launch F&O on BSE Focused IT index



Chennai: BSE on Thursday said it has received approval from SEBI to launch derivative contracts on the ‘BSE Focused IT Index’. The index measures the performance of the 14 companies belonging to the ‘Information Technology’ sector. Details regarding the launch and contract specifications will be notified, BSE said. The BSE had received regulator nod to launch index derivatives on the BSE Sensex Next 30 in March and the BSE Focused Midcap Index in February. **OUR BUREAU**

ASK Property Fund exits two realty deals for ₹400 cr

Mumbai: ASK Property Fund has exited two residential real estate debt investments in Mumbai and Gurugram, collecting a combined ₹400 crore and posting double-digit returns on both deals, the fund announced. The larger of the two exits was in Borivali, Mumbai, where the fund deployed ₹190 crore as growth capital into Kalpataru Group’s redevelopment project, Kalpataru Advay. ASK exited the investment at ₹244 crore, generating an IRR of 18 per cent and a return multiple of 1.3x. The second exit was from Trevoc Royal Residences in Gurugram, NCR, developed by Trevoc Developers. The fund had invested ₹98 crore in the project. Within roughly 18 months of the project’s launch, sales reached 65 per cent, allowing the fund to exit at ₹141 crore, an IRR of 21 per cent and a multiple of 1.44x. **OUR BUREAU**

‘Nifty 50 may reclaim record high this fiscal’

Our Bureau

Indian equity markets could scale back to their all-time highs in the current financial year, with the benchmark Nifty 50 potentially revisiting the 26,000-plus mark, said Dhiraj Relli, Managing Director and CEO of HDFC Securities. Speaking at the firm’s annual market outlook event, Relli said the recent 18-month correction has reset valuations, creating room for an upward move, possibly closer to the festive season, though the exact timing remains uncertain. While earlier projections of 14–15 per cent earnings growth have been moderated, estimates of 10–12 per cent growth are still seen as healthy and more broad-based across sectors. Global factors, however, continue to weigh on sentiment. Currency volatility, particularly dollar strength, and geopolitical tensions, especially in

Markets snap 5-day winning streak on concerns over Iran-US ceasefire

CAUTIOUS MOOD. Banking, financial services and auto lead decliners’ pack, volatility index rises above 20 again

Anupama Ghosh

The markets reversed course on Thursday, with benchmark indices declining after five consecutive sessions of gains, as investor optimism around a US-Iran ceasefire quickly gave way to renewed geopolitical anxiety. The BSE Sensex fell 931 points, or 1.20 per cent, to close at 76,631, while the Nifty 50 shed 222 points, or 0.93 per cent, to end at 23,766. The sell-off followed Wednesday’s sharp 1,800-point rally that had been triggered by ceasefire signals that appeared increasingly fragile by Thursday afternoon. “After Wednesday’s relief

rally following the ceasefire announcement, domestic markets ended a volatile session in red, driven by ceasefire uncertainty,” said Ankur Punj, MD & Business Head, Equirus Wealth.

HARDENING STANCE

The trigger for the reversal was US President Donald Trump reiterating that American forces would remain deployed around Iran until a “real agreement” is implemented, while Israeli strikes in Lebanon continued. Markets, which opened gap-down, briefly touched an intra-day high of 77,429 on the Sensex before sustained selling dragged them to a low of 76,347. Concerns around supply disruptions at the Strait of



BULLISH VIEW. The recent Morgan Stanley India Equity Strategy report provides a longer-term anchor to the current volatility. It maintains a December 2026 Sensex target of 95,000

Hormuz pushed US crude toward \$97 a barrel. FII selling continued, with outflows of nearly ₹38,000 crore in April alone. India VIX, the market’s fear gauge, climbed nearly 5 per cent, crossing the 20 mark.

Sectorally, the damage was concentrated. Banking, financial services, private

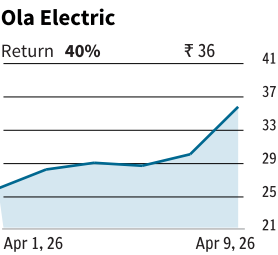
banks, auto, and consumer durables led the decline. Indusind Bank fell 2.69 per cent and HDFC Bank dropped 2.22 per cent. In contrast, metals, power, and pharma outperformed. Hindalco rose 3.30 per cent and NALCO climbed 3.22 per cent. Midcap and smallcap indices held up bet-

ter, with the Nifty Midcap 100 gaining 0.3 per cent. Amit Suri, CFP and Director at AUM Wealth, offered a steadying perspective: “The bigger risk in such phases is not volatility itself, but reacting to it — staying anchored to long-term allocation and discipline is far more important than trying to time these headline-driven moves.” The recent Morgan Stanley India Equity Strategy report provides a longer-term anchor to the current volatility. The firm maintains a December 2026 Sensex target of 95,000, implying 22 per cent upside from current levels, with a base case premised on earnings compounding at 17 per cent annually through FY28.

Ola Electric jumps 20% on new cell development

Our Bureau

Shares of Ola Electric Mobility Ltd hit the upper circuit limit on Thursday, closing at ₹36.32 — up 20 per cent from the previous close of ₹30.27. The stock opened at ₹30.50 and touched a low of ₹30.30 during the day. The rally was triggered by Ola Electric’s recent announcements on the readiness of its 46100 LFP cell, developed in-house. The larger-format cell succeeds the existing 4680 NMC Bharat Cell and is positioned to drive cost reductions across vehicles and energy storage. Commercial deploy-



ment is expected to begin next quarter, it said. The Gigafactory, currently at 2.5 GWh, is being expanded to 6 GWh. The stock’s month-to-date gain now stands at over 56 per cent, extending a recovery that began after March registrations surged 150 per cent year-on-year to 10,117 units per Vahan data.

Zerodha’s Coin offers fixed deposits too

Our Bureau

Zerodha has introduced fixed deposits on its investment platform Coin as the brokerage looks to deepen its play in long-term savings products beyond mutual funds. In a blog post, the company said the move aims to simplify a fragmented FD ecosystem. **WEALTH HUB** “Rates are scattered, processes differ, and tracking maturity dates and interest becomes harder than it should be,” Zerodha said, outlining the need for a unified interface. Coin, which operates separately from Zerodha’s trading app, Kite,



serves as the company’s hub for long-term investments, including mutual funds, insurance, and the National Pension System. With the addition of FDs, users can now allocate savings across both market-linked and fixed-income instruments on a single platform. The feature allows customers to compare FD rates across multiple banks, book deposits digitally, and track key metrics such as invested amount, accrued interest and maturity timelines in one

place. The offering is expected to include deposits from small finance banks, which typically offer higher interest rates. For first-time investments with a bank, users will be required to complete a one-time KYC process. The move comes amid rising interest in digital FD offerings, with several fintech start-ups and investors betting on the space. Wealthtech start-up Stable Money recently raised around \$25 million led by Peak XV Partners. Platforms such as Smallcase and WintWealth, backed by Zerodha’s Rainmatter, as well as Flipkart-backed super.money, have also begun offering FDs, though not as their core product.

Exchanges extend IPO approval validity for SMEs

Our Bureau

Following a relaxation by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) on IPO validity periods, stock exchanges have extended similar relief to SME issuers, offering a cushion to companies delaying public issues due to volatile market conditions. Both the National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) and the BSE announced a one-time extension of in-principle approvals for SME listings that are nearing expiry. The move aligns with SEBI’s circular issued on Tuesday, which allowed flexibility for issuers facing challenges in tapping the capital markets. NSE said the validity of in-principle approvals for listings on NSE Emerge expiring between April 1 and September 30, 2026, will be extended until September



30, 2026. The extension is subject to an undertaking from the lead manager confirming compliance with ICDR regulations at the time of filing the offer document. BSE has issued a similar circular for its SME platform. **LISTING RELIEF** Around 10-15 SME IPOs had approvals nearing expiry, which will have the flexibility to wait for improved market conditions. SEBI said the relaxation follows representations citing fundraising challenges amid global uncertainties, including geopolitical tensions, which have led several companies to defer or withdraw IPO plans.

Capri Global Capital aims to raise ₹500 cr via NCD issue

Our Bureau

Capri Global Capital plans to raise ₹500 crore through the issue of non-convertible debentures. The issue consists of a base issue size of ₹100 crore, with a green shoe option of ₹400 crore. The company, which derives 40 per cent of its revenue from gold loans and 20 per cent from MSMEs, has set a target to raise ₹2,000 crore through NCDs this fiscal. The first tranche of the NCD issue offers investors multiple tenure options of 24 months, 36 months, 60 months and 120 months,

with monthly and annual interest pay-out choices and coupon rates of up to 9.50 per cent. The NCDs will be listed on both the NSE and BSE. The issue opens for subscription on April 15 and closes on April 28. Rajesh Sharma, MD, Capri Global Capital, said, “The company has not experienced any major impact of the ongoing West Asia war on its lending books, but expects a slowdown from industries dependent on LPG.” As far as gold loans are concerned, he said the recent fall in prices has not triggered margin calls in the form of extra cash or gold as the company sticks to a loan-to-value of 60 per cent.

BROKER’S CALL.

Bernstein

APTUS VALUE HOUSING FIN (OUTPERFORM) Target: ₹350 CMP: ₹217.80 Aptus leads the sector on EPS growth at 25 per cent year on year (Q326 TTM), outpacing larger NBFC peers such as BAF (12 per cent), Aavas (11 per cent) and L&T Finance (9 per cent). RoA stays healthy at 7.3-7.4 per cent and NIM at 10.9 per cent, with a cost-to-income ratio of about 20-21 per cent — among the best in the sector. AUM growth guidance revised to 22-24 per cent for the near term, with a medium-term aspiration of ₹25,000 crore by FY29 (about 2x current levels); Aptus plans to open 60-70 new branches in FY27 with a deliberate focus on New-State expansion.

Bernstein

AADHAR HOUSING FINANCE (OUTPERFORM) Target: ₹600 CMP: ₹471.65 AUM grew 21 per cent year on year in Q326, broadly in line with its historical average; the management guides for 18-20 per cent AUM growth in FY27, supported by improving branch vintage and a planned addition of 40-50 new branches. Aadhar’s diversified geographical presence, no single State exceeding 15 per cent of AUM and limited direct MFI customer exposure provided meaningful insulation from microfinance stress and tariff-related disruptions. We highlight Aadhar as one of our top picks in the AHFC segment, citing its diversified geographical presence and proven ability to scale its model successfully across geographies. The prevailing macro concerns have triggered a broad-based sell-off across Indian banks and NBFCs, and affordable housing finance companies (AHFC) have not been spared. However, beyond now-attractive valuations, we see several compelling reasons to turn constructive on the segment, driven by an impending inflection in both growth and asset quality. Further, relative to NBFC peers, stronger liability profiles — supported by longer-tenor borrowings and access to NHB funding — along with the inherently-secured nature of assets and the relatively smaller scale of these franchises, make AHFCs an attractive segment to own in the current environment. AHFCs have seen a sharp moderation in disbursement growth over the past 12 months, broadly in line with prime mortgages. This, along with asset quality concerns — driven by potential spillovers from microfinance as well as idiosyncratic factors (e.g. tariff impact across select industries/geographies) — has led to a meaningful derating across the space. We believe both growth and asset quality are now approaching an inflection point. Q3FY26 results provide early evidence: disbursement growth has shown sequential improvement, while early-stage delinquency indicators have begun to stabilise or improve for most lenders. This reinforces our constructive long-term view on the affordable housing theme, and we view the current correction as a favourable entry point. We maintain our Outperform ratings on Aptus and Aadhar.

TODAY’S PICK.

Belrise Industries (₹202.20): BUY

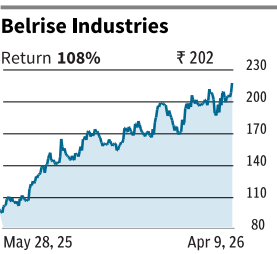
Akhil Nallamuthu
bl_research_bureau

The stock of Belrise Industries has been rallying steadily ever since its listing in May 2025. But for nearly two months now, that is since mid-February, the scrip has largely been trading within a range.

But on Thursday, it broke out of the resistance band of ₹198-200 and hit a lifetime high of ₹204.40.

We expect the stock to rally further, potentially to ₹225 in the near term. But before the next upswing, the scrip can retest ₹198.

So, traders can buy now at ₹202 and accumulate if the price drops to ₹198.



Place initial stop-loss at ₹190. When the price rises to ₹212, raise the stop-loss to ₹205. Tighten the stop-loss further to ₹215 when the stock appreciates to ₹220. Book profits at ₹225.

Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading.

Day trading guide

23865 » Nifty 50 Futures

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
23650	23500	24080	24300	Buy now and on a decline to 23650; place stop-loss at 23500.

₹797 » HDFC Bank

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
792	770	820	850	Buy the stock if it rebounds from 792; place stop-loss at 770.

₹1331 » Infosys

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1315	1300	1360	1380	Stock sustains above a support; buy with stop-loss at 1315.

₹303 » ITC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
301	298	305	310	Go long if the stock breaks out of 305; stop-loss can be 300.

₹288 » ONGC

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
286	282	290	293	The stock might stay sideways; refrain from trading this scrip.

₹1329 » Reliance Ind.

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1325	1305	1338	1350	Go short if the stock slips below 1325; place stop-loss at 1338.

₹1040 » SBI

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
1035	1015	1070	1100	Go short if the stock slips below 1035; place stop-loss at 1050.

₹2587 » TCS

S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT
2560	2515	2625	2670	Go long now and on a dip to 2560; keep a stop-loss at 2515.

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers

	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Hindalco	985.65	10.69	13.78	1.31
TCS	2589.00	6.64	19.53	2.43
Bharat Elec	439.75	5.20	53.91	1.45
WIPAC	378.65	4.65	14.79	1.65
Bajaj Auto	9517.00	3.65	29.94	0.97
PowerGrid Corp	298.10	3.21	17.86	1.24
JSW Steel	1209.70	3.15	38.09	1.04
Dr Reddys Lab	1211.90	2.73	18.31	0.68
ONGC	288.60	2.63	8.07	1.03
Coal India	454.10	2.40	9.41	0.95
NestleIndia	1228.70	2.35	72.64	0.81
Max Healthcare	954.95	2.24	65.48	0.65
Tata Steel	205.20	1.84	28.08	1.56
Apollo Hosp	7481.50	1.80	57.65	0.71
Tech Mahindra	1461.60	1.41	31.19	0.85
1078.00	1.35	72.49	0.64	
TataConsumerProduct	303.00	1.16	18.34	2.68
Cipla	1224.00	1.04	21.82	0.63
HCL Tech	1464.90	0.90	24.13	1.42
Sun Pharma	1717.10	0.58	37.61	1.67
Eicher Motors	7147.50	0.50	36.60	0.90
Adani Enter	2040.50	-0.19	16.66	0.49
Wipro	202.87	-0.34	15.96	0.53
SBI Life	1504.00	-0.35	77.03	0.78
Maruti Suzuki	13589.00	-0.37	28.61	1.64
Tata Motors PV	333.25	-0.69	45.32	0.64
Adani Ports	1447.40	-0.95	26.68	0.98
Asian Paints	2269.60	-1.26	55.68	0.94
Greaves Ind	2740.50	-1.30	30.69	0.96
Bharti Airtel	1859.40	-1.47	30.98	5.74
HDFC Life	591.20	-1.67	67.48	0.58
Bajaj Finserv	1767.70	-2.13	14.74	0.94
Hind Unilever	2133.20	-2.40	49.85	1.74
Trent Ltd.	3850.70	-2.63	84.51	0.78
UltraTech Cement	11448.00	-4.00	44.02	1.24
Titan	4439.55	-4.74	82.70	1.68
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	238.84	-5.74	94.55	0.72
Bajaj Finance	903.25	-6.89	30.67	2.22
IntGlobeavi	4449.10	-8.21	53.57	0.92
Shriram Finance Ltd.	996.30	-8.22	20.49	1.28
M&M	3166.80	-8.44	23.30	2.60
Eramil Ltd.	423.15	-8.29	93.82	1.57
Axis Bank	1318.50	-9.08	15.51	3.47
Infosys	1331.60	-11.17	19.28	4.28
Kotak Bank	371.90	-13.25	19.68	2.51
State Bank	1040.95	-18.56	11.10	3.96
Reliance Ind	1330.00	-26.23	18.41	8.24
LCI Bank	3896.20	-28.10	28.24	4.20
HDFC Bank	1281.30	-43.52	16.20	8.41
HDFC Bank	797.70	-61.44	15.86	11.20

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN%
Vedanta	737.00	74.83	17.39	5.33
Hindustanaeronautics	4032.90	67.16	30.32	3.26
Power Finance	428.05	42.75	4.23	2.66
Cummins India	4907.40	42.36	60.68	2.56
Adani Power	172.33	35.26	29.41	3.04
Divis Lab	5952.50	25.29	63.74	3.22
Bosch	36770.00	20.44	39.34	1.36
Avenuesuper	4415.60	19.45	100.32	2.77
Torrent Pharma	4094.50	19.28	60.99	1.82
Solar Industries	13928.00	18.29	82.55	1.45
Tes Motor Cmp	3727.10	17.04	57.99	3.73
Siemens Energy India	2767.70	16.48	83.44	1.04
Rural Elec	346.80	14.63	5.30	1.85
AdaniGreenenergy	1044.55	14.10	92.70	1.49
Ltimindtree	4572.00	12.83	28.70	1.81
Magazam Dock	2435.50	8.69	40.82	0.79
Macrotech Developers	789.55	8.50	23.57	1.96
Zykluslifestyles	902.25	7.56	18.06	0.96
Abb India	6614.00	7.26	83.11	1.48
Adani Energy Solutions	1078.75	5.34	54.36	1.59
Varun Beverages	422.90	3.86	46.71	2.47
United Spirits	1249.70	0.75	52.85	1.57
Tata Capital	326.15	-0.30	30.32	0.60
Siemens	3222.50	-0.90	72.38	1.21
Hindus Zinc	558.50	-1.04	20.00	1.03
Tata Power	394.70	-1.18	25.18	2.81
Indian Railway Finance Corp	98.49	-2.38	18.37	0.84
Hyundai Motor India	1768.30	-4.27	24.81	1.07
Bpcl	297.35	-4.29	5.24	2.57
Union Bank	1384.69	-5.29	7.44	1.52
Pitdillind	1347.40	-6.65	59.26	1.78
Bajaj Holdings	9912.50	-7.03	12.31	1.83
Gail (India)	152.22	-8.22	11.63	1.75
Muthootfin	3475.20	-8.51	16.12	1.59
Bank Of Baroda	274.24	-9.11	7.22	2.17
Cg Power & Ind Sol	720.60	-11.04	102.29	2.11
Canara Bank	137.91	-12.18	6.79	1.98
Gdrej Consumer	1063.35	-13.40	59.73	1.82
Shree Cement	23990.00	-13.97	48.19	1.37
Hdfc Amc	2515.00	-14.03	37.49	2.18
Jindal Steel	1199.60	-14.11	60.70	1.89
Punjab Natl Bank	1097.50	-15.89	7.05	1.61
SamarudhetherosInternat	116.90	-15.12	33.90	2.20
Indian Oilcorp	141.67	-17.72	5.43	2.25
Dif	562.95	-17.93	31.47	1.54

Mumbai: Equinix, a digital infrastructure company, unveiled MB3, its fourth International Business Exchange (IBX) data centre in Mumbai. Located in Chandivali, Powai, MB3 is the third Equinix data centre to be set up in central Mumbai. With an initial investment of over \$95 million, MB3 provides more than 1,370 cabinets of capacity. **OUR BUREAU**

QUICKLY.

Amazon Now plans to enter US and Europe



New Delhi: E-commerce firm Amazon is planning to expand its quick commerce vertical Amazon Now in the US and Europe after its success in India, according to a document from the company. The company started Amazon Now last year in India and the UAE. “We’ve been working on Amazon Now, ultra-fast delivery on thousands of items within 20 minutes. Customers love this service. We’re starting to expand Amazon Now in the US and Europe, too,” the document said. ^{PTI}

GAIL (India) to borrow ₹6,000 cr for expansion

New Delhi: GAIL (India) plans to borrow ₹5,000-6,000 crore in fiscal 2027 to fund expansion, and has bought three spot LNG cargoes to offset supply shortages caused by the Iran war, a company executive said on Thursday. The amount it plans to borrow would be the equivalent of \$539-647 million. ^{REUTERS}

Mudra loan disbursals hit a record ₹5.64 lakh cr in FY26

GREEN SHOOTS. NPAs down to about 2 per cent from 4.86 per cent five years ago

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

The disbursal of business loans under the Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana (PMMY) reached an all-time high in the financial year ended March 31, 2026, at ₹5.64 lakh crore compared to ₹5.4 lakh crore in the previous financial year. As per data, total disbursals stood at ₹5,64,784 crore out of the total sanctioned amount of ₹5,74,389 crore. The number of loans was at 4,57,01,308.

VARIOUS CATEGORIES

The categories of loans are Shishu, for loans of up to ₹50,000; Kishore, for loans above ₹50,000 and up to ₹5 lakh; and Tarun, for loans above ₹5 lakh and up to ₹10 lakh. Another variant, Tarun-plus, for loans above ₹10 lakh and up to ₹20 lakh was introduced in FY25. “The increase in the upper limit of Tarun category loans has resulted in an overall in-



CREDIT PUSH. The Pradhan Mantri Mudra Yojana has disbursed over ₹40.07 lakh crore through 57.79 crore loans

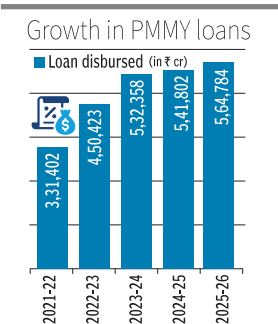
crease in the quantum of the loans under PMMY but also fostered repayment discipline,” a Mudra official told *businessline*. However, over 60 per cent of loans are still below ₹30,000, which shows the “popularity and efficacy” of the scheme for livelihood generation and starting or running petty businesses, he added.

The improvement in asset quality has been a notable feature in the last financial year, according to a senior SBI official.

As per Finance Ministry data, non-performing assets (NPAs) in Mudra loans stood around 2 per cent, down significantly from 4.86 per cent five years ago.

FINANCIAL INCLUSION

The financial inclusion campaign launched by the public sector banks last year along with revival of dormant accounts had also created more awareness on the Mudra loans, especially among the poor women who were now showing greater interest in the scheme has also been one



Source: Mudra

of the drivers for growth in advances, say bankers.

The Credit Guarantee Fund for Micro Units (CG-FMU), the official scheme that provides guarantee cover for loans sanctioned under the Pradhan Mantri MUDRA Yojana (PMMY), is also pushing banks to lend without any concern over repayment though the NPAs were under healthy limits.

PMMY has disbursed over ₹40.07 lakh crore through 57.79 crore loans, strengthening the credit ecosystem for small and micro enterprises, as on March 27.

Tractor makers to hike prices this month as input rates bite

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

Tractor manufacturers are rolling out price hikes through April, led by market leader Mahindra & Mahindra, as rising commodity costs and inflationary pressures push the industry towards coordinated margin protection.

Mahindra & Mahindra said it will increase prices across its domestic tractor range effective April 8, attributing the move to “cost escalations in input commodities”, with hikes varying across models and geographies.

COST PRESSURES

Within the group, Swaraj Tractors also announced a similar increase effective April 21, citing the same reason of rising input costs, with price revisions differing by model and geography.

Escorts Kubota, which had earlier announced price hikes for its standard tractor range, has now extended the increase to its Kubota-branded tractors as well, with effect from April 15, with revisions varying across



COMING SOON

M&M, along with group firm Swaraj Tractors, and Escorts Kubota have announced price hikes across their tractor ranges effective between April 8 and April 21

geographies. The inclusion of Kubota, typically positioned at the premium end, signals that cost pressures are no longer limited to entry- and mid-segment tractors, but are now spreading across the value chain.

INDUSTRY TREND

The back-to-back announcements signal the start of a

broader industry-wide pricing cycle, while players such as TAFE and Sonalika are expected to recalibrate prices.

At TAFE, management commentary accompanying its FY26 performance pointed to “inflationary pressures from ongoing geopolitical tensions” impacting input costs, indicating ongoing price realignments across its Massey Ferguson and Eicher tractor portfolio.

“Rising geopolitical developments are beginning to feed into input costs and supply chains, prompting manufacturers to recalibrate pricing to protect margins,” said Hemal Thakkar, Senior Director and Senior Practice Leader, Crisil Research, adding that as growth moderates in FY27, maintaining profitability becomes as important as sustaining volumes..

The staggered hikes come even as the tractor industry remains supported by stable rural demand and strong FY26 volumes.

However, analysts expect cost pressures, to persist, making calibrated price increases a key lever for profitability for tractor manufacturers.

Construction equipment sales fall 13% in FY26 on project delays, weak execution: FADA

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

The construction equipment (CE) segment emerged as the only laggard in the automobile retail market in FY26, even as all other segments posted growth, according to data from the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA).

CE retail sales declined 13 per cent year-on-year to 71,227 units in FY26, compared with 80,668 units in the previous year, reflecting a broad-based slowdown across the sector.

FADA President GS Vigneshwar attributed the decline to multiple factors, including project-level delays, a high base effect, delays in mining licences and the impact of unseasonal rains. He said that it was in FY26 that FADA, for the first time, released separate retail data for the CE segment, which was earlier clubbed with commercial vehicles.

SHARP DECLINE

Market leader JCB India Ltd



Sales retreat

	FY25	Market share (%)	FY26	Market Share (%)
JCB India Ltd	39,782	49.3	34,632	48.6
Action Construction Equipment	9,258	11.5	7,416	10.4
Ajax Engineering	4,984	6.2	4,622	6.5
Escorts Kubota Ltd (CE)	5,474	6.8	4,556	6.4
Tata Hitachi Construction Machinery	1,943	2.4	1,934	2.7

Source: FADA

saw its retail sales fall 15 per cent to 34,632 units, with its market share slipping marginally to 48.62 per cent from 49.32 per cent a year earlier.

The second-largest player, Action Construction Equipment Ltd, reported a sharper 25 per cent decline, while Ajax Engineering Ltd, ranked third, saw volumes drop 8 per cent. Interestingly, Ajax Engineering has overtaken Escorts Kubota (CE) to take the third spot in FY26.

Among the 14 OEMs

tracked by FADA, only three companies — Bull Machines Pvt Ltd, All Terrain Crane, and Liugong India — registered growth, albeit on a low base.

P Parthiban, Managing Director of the Coimbatore-based Bull Machines, said the market remains volatile, with capital-intensive buying decisions being deferred amid weak sentiment influenced by global factors such as US tariff concerns and geopolitical tensions. He ad-

ded that despite the downturn, the company did well last fiscal and have room to grow through operational efficiency.

KEY FACTORS

Poonam Upadhyay of Crisil Ratings highlighted that FY26 volumes were impacted by slower project execution and a high base created by pre-buying in FY25 ahead of the rollout of CEV Stage V emission norms in January 2025, which increased equipment costs.

She added that the roads sector, accounting for nearly 40 per cent of CE demand, had seen slower project mobilisation and execution.

Unseasonal rain and delays in residential real estate clearances, particularly in Maharashtra and Karnataka, had further dampened demand.

Additionally, unlike automobiles and tractors that benefited from GST rate cuts, CE continues to be taxed at 18 per cent, limiting price-driven demand support and keeping ownership costs elevated, she said.

Milky Mist beats FY26 growth estimates; IPO on track: CEO

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

Milky Mist has beaten its own revenue growth estimates in FY26 driven by broad-based growth across ice creams, beverages, paneer, cheese and other categories and a stand-out performance of the emerging protein offerings, K Rathnam, CEO and Whole-time Director, Milky Mist Dairy Food, told *businessline*.

“The ballpark figure, what we estimated was 33 per cent top line growth. And we have achieved a 34 per cent top line growth. Whatever the estimates we did at the beginning of the year, we are able to exceed the target,” he said.

Being a complete value-added dairy company, and having the products starting from breakfast to dinner table, we are in a better position despite the macro situation and see a bright future, he observed. The company clocked revenue of around ₹3,275 crore in FY26.

IPO PLAN

Founded in Erode, Tamil Nadu, Milky Mist is one of the leading dairy brands in India, producing value-added dairy products such as paneer, cheese, yogurt, curd, ice cream, butter and ghee. It does not sell milk, enabling higher margins and strong positioning akin to FMCG companies.



K Rathnam, CEO and Whole-time Director, Milky Mist Dairy Food

The dairy value-add company, which obtained approval from SEBI for its ₹2,035 crore IPO in October 2025, said it is evaluating the market conditions and looking for the “right opportunity” to kick off the listing. The IPO is definitely on track, he added, noting that the SEBI approval expires in October this year. The offer comprises a fresh issue of up to ₹1,785 crore and an offer for sale of up to ₹250 crore by promoter shareholders.

An early and intense summer has set the demand for ice creams and beverages going up already, at a rate higher than last summer, Rathnam said.

The 15-20 per cent increase in packaging material cost may impact the bottom-line marginally, he added. “More and more demand is coming for our high protein

categories like Greek yogurt, high-protein paneer and high-protein cheddar, among others. In protein offerings, we have been growing 100 per cent as compared to the last year.”

MANUFACTURING PLANS

As for capacity planning, Rathnam noted that the company’s efforts to expand production in the last two years has now become operational, and there is still a large headroom for capacity expansion. “Our existing plant (in Tamil Nadu) can do three times or three to four times of revenue what we have achieved now in FY26,” he said.

The company, which recently signed an investment MoU with the Maharashtra government, has now taken possession of a land parcel at Baramati, and the facility is in the planning stage.

“About 25-30 per cent of our revenue comes from non-South regions, so it makes sense for us to have decentralised, manufacturing operations,” he said.

QUICK COMMERCE

As for the bump in business from the quick commerce wave, Rathnam said that quick commerce is now “a way of life” in India.

“It’s not a hype, but it’s a reality; they are doing well,” he said. The channel now contributes 10 per cent of revenue for Milky Mist.

Prestige Estates crosses ₹30,000 cr in FY26 pre-sales

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Real estate major Prestige Estates Projects Ltd has recorded a 76 per cent growth in annual pre-sales, reaching ₹30,024 crore for FY26, with ₹7,697 crore (up 10 per cent year-on-year) recorded in the fourth quarter alone.

The growth was driven by new supply hitting the market with strong contributions from NCR and other key cities. This comes at a time when India’s housing market is showing early signs of moderation after a strong post-pandemic run, with analysts flagging softer demand sentiment, delayed project launches and rising input costs amid global geopolitical uncertainties.

STEADY DEMAND

The company has launched 15 projects with gross development value of ₹26,000-27,000 crore throughout the year.

The company witnessed sustained traction across its key markets, supported by steady demand for well-located, high-quality developments.

Commenting on the performance, Irfan Razack, CMD, said: “With a robust pipeline of upcoming launches across geographies, we are optimistic about sustaining this momentum in the coming year.”

TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)
The Tata Power Company Limited, Smart Center of Procurement Excellence, 2nd Floor, Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Sahar Airport Road, Andheri (E), Mumbai-400059
(Board Line: 022-67173168) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567

NOTICE INVITING TENDER
The Tata Power Company Limited invites tenders from eligible vendors for the following packages (Two Part Bidding).
1) 4100063124/CC26ADO027 - Onsite Meter Testing, Data Entry Operator and Meter Data Download Services.
2) 4100063637 - SITC & Replacement of Access Control system across Tata Power
Last date for Bid Submission: 30th April 2026, 3:00 PM
For detailed NIT, please visit Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com>. Also, all future corrigendum's if any, to the said tender will be informed on Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com> only.

TATA POWER
(Corporate Contracts Department)
Sahar Receiving Station, Near Hotel Leela, Andheri (E), Mumbai 400 059, Maharashtra, India
(Board Line: 022-67173992) CIN: L28920MH1919PLC000567

NOTICE INVITING EXPRESSION OF INTEREST
The Tata Power Company Limited hereby invites Expression of Interest (EOI) from eligible bidders for participation in following tender:
"On-Board Protecting Agency Services for Coal Unloading Operations at Trombay Plant, Mumbai"
(Tender Ref: TPCL/C/FY27/AK001)
For details of Tender scope, Pre-qualification requirements, process of participation in tender, tender fee and bid security etc., please visit Tender section of our website (URL: <https://www.tatapower.com/tender>) and refer detailed Tender Notice. Eligible bidders willing to participate in tender may submit their Expression of Interest along with the tender fee latest by **16th Apr 2026**.
Future corrigendum's (if any), to the above tenders will be published on Tender section on website <https://www.tatapower.com> only.

TATA CONSULTANCY SERVICES LIMITED
Registered Office: 9th Floor, Nirmal Building, Nariman Point, Mumbai 400 021. Tel: +91 22 6778 9595 Fax: +91 22 6778 9660
e-mail: investor.relations@tcs.com website: www.tcs.com CIN: L22210MH1995PLC084781

Extract of the audited consolidated financial results for the year ended March 31, 2026 (₹ crore)

	Three months ended March 31, 2026	Year ended March 31, 2026	Three months ended March 31, 2025
Revenue from operations	70,698	2,67,021	64,479
Profit before exceptional items and tax	18,362	70,013	16,402
Profit before tax	18,362	65,487	16,402
Profit after tax	13,784	49,454	12,293
Total comprehensive income for the period	14,445	52,204	12,855
Paid up equity share capital (Face value: ₹1 per share)	362	362	362
Total reserves (including non-controlling interests)*	1,08,116	1,08,116	95,409
Earnings per equity share:- Basic and diluted (₹)	37.92	136.01	33.79

*Balance for three months and year ended March 31, 2026 represent balance as per the audited consolidated balance sheet for the year ended March 31, 2026 and balance for three months ended March 31, 2025, represent balance as per the audited consolidated balance sheet for the year ended March 31, 2025 as required by Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015.

Extract of the audited standalone financial results for the year ended March 31, 2026 (₹ crore)

	Three months ended March 31, 2026	Year ended March 31, 2026	Three months ended March 31, 2025
Revenue from operations	58,052	2,20,938	54,136
Profit before exceptional items and tax	18,464	66,873	14,672
Profit before tax	18,464	62,806	14,672
Profit after tax	14,526	49,096	11,116
Total comprehensive income for the period	14,100	48,496	11,194

Notes:
1. The audited consolidated financial results and audited standalone financial results have been reviewed by the Audit Committee and approved by the Board of Directors at its meeting held on April 9, 2026. The statutory auditors have expressed an unmodified audit opinion on these results.
2. The Board of Directors at its meeting held on April 9, 2026, has proposed a final dividend of ₹31.00 per equity share.
3. On January 14, 2026, ListEngage Midco, LLC, a wholly owned subsidiary of the Company, acquired 100% of the ownership interest of Coastal Cloud Holdings, LLC along with its subsidiaries ("Coastal Cloud") for a consideration of \$707 million (₹6,386 crore).
4. The above is an extract of the detailed format of financial results filed with the Stock Exchanges under Regulation 33 of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015. The full format for three months ended and year ended March 31, 2026, are available on the BSE Limited website (URL: www.bseindia.com), the National Stock Exchange of India Limited website (URL: www.nseindia.com) and on the Company's website (URL: www.tcs.com/investors). The same can be accessed by scanning the QR code provided below.

Mumbai
April 9, 2026

For and on behalf of the Board of Directors

K Krithivasan
CEO and Managing Director
DIN: 10106739

QUICKLY.

Gold prices firm, spotlight on US-Iran ceasefire



Gold prices firmed on Thursday as a weaker US dollar lent support, while investors assessed the durability of a fragile ceasefire between Washington and Tehran and awaited US Consumer Price Index data. Spot gold was up 0.9 per cent at \$4,755.99 per ounce, at 9.16 am ET (1316 GMT). US gold edged up 0.1 per cent to \$4,781.80. REUTERS

Copper slips on doubts about US-Iran ceasefire

London: Copper prices slipped on Thursday as doubts about whether the US-Iran ceasefire would hold reinforced concerns about global growth and demand for industrial metals, traders said. Benchmark copper on the LME traded 1.2 per cent lower at \$12,551 a tonne in official rings. REUTERS

Palm oil prices rise over 1% on bargain buying



Kuala Lumpur: Malaysian palm oil futures settled more than 1 per cent higher on Thursday, recouping some of the previous session's losses, supported by bargain buying amid a rebound in crude oil prices. The benchmark palm oil contract for June delivery on the Bursa Malaysia Derivatives Exchange climbed 56 ringgit to 4,642 ringgit (\$1,166.33) a tonne at the close. REUTERS

Rain, hailstorms may dent wheat output

MAJOR LOSS. 111 districts in 9 States affected by vagaries of weather; 5-10% drop in production estimated

Prabhudatta Mishra
New Delhi

Unseasonal rain and hailstorms in March and April have impacted wheat crops across 111 districts in nine States, leading to an estimated 5-10 per cent drop in overall production. Agriwatch, in a report for the Roller Flour Millers Federation of India, warned that up to 30 per cent of the harvest in affected areas suffers from quality degradation, including shrivelled grains and lustre loss. The government estimated wheat production this year at a record 120.21 million tonnes. In a report submitted to the industry body, Agriwatch informed that a total of 111 districts were affected, with damage ranging between as low as 3 per cent and as high

as 25 per cent due to rain and recent hailstorms, sources said. **BADLY HIT** In Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Haryana and Bihar, harvesting has been completed in 10-15 per cent of the area. The report said the crop in maturity-to-harvest stages, damage has been reported in 25-30 per cent of area. Maximum damage of 15-25 per cent was reported from Punjab's Amritsar, Hoshiarpur and Rupnagar (earlier Ropar) districts, Haryana's Rewari, Uttar Pradesh's Hamirpur, Bihar's Begusarai and West Bengal's Dakshin Dinajpur. Similarly, three districts in Punjab and one each in Uttar Pradesh and Bihar may have 10-15 per cent loss in production, sources said, quoting from the report. A maximum of 51 districts



DIM PROSPECTS. The government estimated wheat production this year at a record 120.21 million tonnes

in eight States may have 3-5 per cent crop loss, particularly in areas where there was unseasonal rain and hailstorms. Though the report said that in Bikaner, wheat output may suffer a 3-5 per cent loss, it was the most badly affected district in terms of damage due to hailstorms on

April 2. The government has a target to buy 303.36 lakh tonnes (lt) of wheat for the Central Pool stock by June 30. Central teams have already been sent to Rajasthan and Haryana to assess crop damage after the State governments' requested relaxation in quality

norms for procurement. On the wheat crop outlook, Food Secretary Sanjeev Chopra, earlier this week, said it was looking good but there were requests from Haryana and Rajasthan for relaxation of the FAQ (fair average quality) norms after the unseasonal rain hit the crop. "We have sent our teams to these States to find out the ground-level position and, if required, we'll give them the relaxation very soon so that farmers do not suffer any problem in selling the produce," he said. Agriwatch last month submitted a preliminary report to the flour millers' body, where it mentioned that farmers in many of the affected districts had suffered lodging and damage to matured crops from hailstorm, affecting quality and potentially lustre loss in the grain.

Maharashtra govt expands agri oversight structure

Our Bureau
Pune

The Maharashtra government has issued a notification amending its earlier provisions under the Insecticides Act, 1968, to strengthen administrative oversight in the agriculture sector. The notification, released by the Agriculture, Animal Husbandry, Dairy Development and Fisheries Department, introduces new appointments at the divisional, district and taluka levels. Per the order, a new post of Technical Officer (Quality Control) has been added at the divisional level. The officers will function under the office of the Divisional Joint Director of Agriculture and

will be appointed across various agricultural divisions. **AGRI OFFICERS** At the district level, the government has introduced the position of Campaign Officer within the Zilla Parishad framework. These officers will be deployed in districts to oversee implementation and co-ordination of agricultural campaigns and related initiatives. The notification also provides for the appointment of Agriculture Officers (Group-B, Junior) at the taluka level under Panchayat Samitis. By expanding the administrative structure, the government aims to enhance efficiency in monitoring, outreach and service delivery in the agriculture sector.

Tap zaid season window after rabi loss: CropLife

Our Bureau
New Delhi

CropLife India, an industry body of pesticides manufacturers, has issued an advisory for the ongoing sowing of crops in the zaid season, urging farmers to prioritise timely sowing, science-based crop protection and responsible input sourcing after unseasonal rain and hailstorms impacted rabi crops in several States. After the loss of some rabi crops, the cropping window in the current zaid season (which falls after rabi and before the kharif season) is critical for farmers to raise their income this year, it said. "Farmers who have suffered rabi losses cannot afford to miss the zaid window. Every week of delay in

sowing compresses the growing period and directly reduces yields. Our advisory focuses on what farmers can act on right now — selecting heat-tolerant varieties, ensuring irrigation every five to seven days, using mulch to conserve moisture and regular scouting for pests, such as red spider mites, aphids and fruit flies, whose cycles accelerate in summer heat," said Durgesh Chandra, Secretary General, CropLife India. "With residual moisture from unseasonal rain still present in some areas, vigilance against fungal diseases is equally important. Timely, need-based use of crop protection products, in line with label directions and good agricultural practices, can make a significant difference in protecting yields during



RAIN WOES. Successive western disturbances have damaged harvest-ready rabi crops across Rajasthan, Haryana, Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and other States

this short but vital season," he added. Successive western disturbances have damaged harvest-ready rabi crops across Rajasthan, Haryana, Uttar

Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh and other States, CropLife said in a statement. This prompted Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan to direct offi-

cials to expedite coordinated crop loss assessments. In several regions, the disruptions delayed field preparation for the zaid crops, it said. **IRAN WAR IMPACT** Besides, disruptions to global supply chains and key shipping routes due to the conflict in West Asia have raised input costs, including for crop protection across agricultural sectors. Though the decision to temporarily waive customs duty on key petrochemical inputs is a welcome step, the full benefit is expected to materialise only in subsequent production cycles. A weaker monsoon outlook makes zaid season returns even more important as a financial buffer ahead of an uncertain kharif, it said.

Less than 10% of major reservoirs have over 80% storage

Our Bureau
Chennai

Less than 10 per cent of India's 166 major reservoirs had storage above 80 per cent, while 55 per cent of them were filled below 45 per cent of the capacity, according to data from the Central Water Commission (CWC). Overall, the level dropped below 45 per cent this week. The storage in reservoirs dropped this week despite a major part of the country receiving excess pre-monsoon rain, data from the India Meteorological Department (IMD) showed. Over 60 per cent of the 725 districts received excess or normal rain since March 1. However, deficient rainfall in over 70 per cent of the country during January-February brought down the storage sharply.



The CWC, in its weekly report, said storage in the major reservoirs dropped to 44.7 per cent or 82.070 billion cubic metres (BCM) of the 183.565 BCM capacity. The level was 18 percentage points higher than a year ago and 27 percentage points more than normal (last 10 years). **PRECARIOUS SOUTH** Storage in all the five regions slipped below 55 per cent, with the level in the southern

region below 35 per cent (also below a year ago). The western region's level was the highest at 53.63 per cent. In the 47 reservoirs of the southern region, storage dropped to 33.6 per cent of the 55.288 BCM at 18.593 BCM. In the western region's 53 reservoirs, the level was 20.439 BCM of the 38.094 BCM. The level in the northern region's 11 reservoirs was 44 per cent of the 19.836 BCM capacity at 8.703 BCM. The 28 reservoirs in the central region were filled to 52 per cent or 25.152 BCM of the 48.588 BCM capacity. In the eastern region's 27 reservoirs, storage was 42 per cent of the 21.759 BCM capacity at 9.183 BCM. With unseasonal rain lashing many parts of the country, the drop in storage will likely slow a tad in the coming week.

Lead futures: Go long at ₹195, stop-loss at ₹192

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

Lead futures are currently hovering around ₹195 (per kg). The trend has been up since mid-March and as it stands, the outlook remains positive. **COMMODITY CALL.** April futures rebounded about three weeks ago after finding support at ₹188. But since the beginning of the current month, the contract has largely been charting a sideways trend between ₹194 and ₹198. Nevertheless, the price action retains the positive inclination, and it will remain so as long as the support at ₹194 stays valid. This is the 21-day moving average support around ₹192.50, thus making the



price band of ₹192.50-194 a good base. We expect the contract to eventually break out of ₹198 and rise to ₹203. However, if the contract slips below the support at ₹192.50, it could extend the decline to ₹188. A breach of this could turn the outlook bearish. Support below ₹188 is at ₹185. Overall, the existing price action indicates that the outlook is positive. **TRADE STRATEGY** Go long on lead futures (April) at ₹195. Target and stop-loss can be ₹203 and ₹192 respectively.

StarAgri plans N-E expansion to tap growing agri ecosystem

Our Bureau
Bangaluru

Agritech start-up StarAgri on Thursday announced plans to expand operations across North-East India as part of a broader strategy to build a strong, scalable presence in the region's growing agricultural ecosystem. The expansion aligns with the company's long-term strategy to tap emerging markets, both in India and internationally, with high potential for agri-value creation, StarAgri said in a statement. As part of its expansion, StarAgri aims to partner with local warehouse owners to standardise and upgrade facilities for the scientific storage of regional commodities. The company will expand workforce through its Guwahati branch office, hiring local youth for warehouse



Amith Agarwal, Co-founder and CEO, StarAgri

operations, Star Labs (quality testing) and administrative roles. A key objective is to reduce losses from wastage and pilferage while enhancing quality and quantity assurance. Farmers and traders will be supported through a "phygital" model, integrating physical storage with online buying and selling via the Agribazaar platform. Amith Agarwal, Co-founder & CEO, StarAgri, said, "We are proud to

deepen our operations and services across the North-Eastern States. The continued efforts of the Central and State governments in strengthening infrastructure, particularly motorable roads, bridges and railway services, create the right foundation for us to build scientific, efficient and farmer-friendly agri-infrastructure that supports the region's growth." **WAREHOUSE UPGRADE** Through this expansion, StarAgri aims to upgrade local warehouses on long-lease or managed models, strengthen quality-testing infrastructure and create regional employment opportunities. By combining physical infrastructure with digital access to markets, the company aims to support local farmers, traders and the agri-economy across the North-East.

Yara rams up digital strategy to boost retailer connectivity

Our Bureau
Bangaluru

Fertilizer major Yara India is sharpening its business development strategy by doubling down on sustainable crop nutrition and digital agriculture. As part of its long-term growth vision in the country, Yara is enhancing last-mile product traceability by onboarding a majority of its key channel partners onto the Retailer Ordering System, a key feature of Yara Connect, the retailer-facing mobile application, the company said in a statement.

VARIOUS INITIATIVES With growing demand for biological solutions in agriculture, the company is also scaling its R&D efforts to expand its biologicals portfolio

and introduce more advanced, sustainable products for farmers. Over the years, Yara India has advanced sustainability through responsible manufacturing and digital advisory tools. It has also strengthened soil health initiatives and collaboration with FPOs and government partners. As the company completes 15 years of operations in India, Sanjiv Kanwar, MD, Yara South Asia, said, "Over the past 15 years, we have partnered closely with farmers, governments and industry stakeholders to drive sustainable, innovation-led agricultural growth. India remains a strategic market for Yara and as we look ahead, our focus is on deepening our commitment to innovation, sustainability and farmer prosperity."

Indore-based firm sets up solar power plants under PM-KUSUM scheme

Subramani Ra Mancombu
Chennai

Indore-based Solarsure, an engineering, procurement and construction firm, has commissioned plants with a capacity of over 300 MW under the PM-KUSUM scheme, benefiting farmers. It has in the pipeline projects totalling 1.5 GW, said Founder Bhavesh Patidar. The company has enabled over 50,000 farmers in the country to get irrigation through solar power through the *Pradhan Mantri Kisan Urja Suraksha evam Uttan Mahabhigyan* (PM-KUSUM) scheme. This has cut their dependence on erratic power supply in some underdeveloped rural areas and on diesel, while increasing farmers' income by 30 per cent. "We are not just raising the income of the farmers, we are also cre-

ating a huge impact on society," said Patidar. **CUTTING INPUT COSTS** Solarsure says its objective is not just about installing solar infrastructures, but giving farmers predictability: The ability to irrigate on time, reduce input costs and, in many cases, generate surplus power. In regions where electricity access has historically been unreliable, this shift is directly impacting crop cycles, yield quality and financial stability at the household level, he said. The company mainly operates in the PM-KUSUM space, where it is the leader. It also works with the carbon-neutral industrial (CNI) sector, helping units to reduce their electricity bills and make them comply with deregulations. These units have certain regulations, mainly to re-



POWERING FARMERS. Solarsure says its objective is to give farmers predictability: The ability to irrigate on time, reduce input costs and generate surplus power

duce pollution. Solarsure, which is focusing on farmer-first deployment of solar plants in States such as Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Uttar Pradesh, is waiting for the implementation of PM-KUSUM 2.0. "The policy is yet to be published," said the company's Founder. The PPA provide the com-

pany with the necessary land to establish the plant. The company sets up the plant on behalf of the farmers, who benefit from the income that is generated from the plant. "We explain the entire cycle, how we'll go about developing a plan, the different stages and where we need their support. In addition, we discuss components that we will be installing on their farms and what kind of returns they could expect from power generation," said Patidar. Farmers are offered three options. One is to sell the power to the government, and different plans are made available. Solarsure promotes the use of agri-voltex or agri-PVs. This will help farmers get double the benefit as they can sow crops, while also selling power to the government. Solarsure initially began with a plant in Madhya Pra-

desh's Indore district. Soon, it expanded to Khargone, Barwani, Malwa, Neemuch, Mandsaur, Gwalior and Morea districts. "When we established a 2 megawatt plant near my village in Indore district, the farmers were getting electricity for only 4 hours during the daytime. They had to wake up in the middle of the night to irrigate their plants. Once we installed the power plant, they have been getting power continuously in the entire area," said the company's Founder. Solarsure makes use of artificial intelligence for setting up the power plants. It taps into satellite data on weather provided by agencies such as the Indian Space Research Organisation and NASA for risk evaluation. "All these data sources are combined, and the risk is evaluated for any given land," said Patidar.

QUICKLY.

Eyeing 400 hotels in 5 years: Sarovar Hotels CEO

New Delhi: Sarovar Hotels is embarking on a long-term strategic expansion targeting a total of 400 hotels in the next five years, with double-digit revenue growth, according to its CEO Jatin Khanna. The company, which has a workforce of over 10,000 people in hotels currently, expects to add a similar number of people as part of its expansion programme, Khanna said. **PTI**

India, Bhutan to deepen energy ties

New Delhi: Power Minister Manohar Lal met Bhutan king Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuck and discussed ways to strengthen the bilateral energy cooperation as well as the development of hydro-electric projects in the neighbouring country. The Minister said he will witness the commencement of dam construction works for the 1,200-MW Punatsangchhu-I Hydroelectric Project on Friday. **PTI**

Defence Ministry pushes for complete indigenisation of integrated munitions

BECOMING WAR-READY. Explosives manufacturing licences being issued to companies, including start-ups

Dalip Singh
New Delhi

As the Ministry of Defence pushes for complete indigenisation of ammunition to ensure self-sufficiency for long-drawn wars, explosives manufacturing licences are being issued to companies, including start-ups. These firms will produce ordnance and integrated munitions for autonomous and unmanned systems to enhance precision strike capabilities. As of December last, the Army had indigenised 159 out of 175 ammunition variants, clocking a self-sufficiency level of 91 per cent to reduce import dependence. The Ministry intends to cut down the gap between the availability of unmanned systems and accompanying integrated ammunition, said sources. One of the start-ups that has got industrial explosives



SEAMLESS INTEGRATION. The Ministry intends to reduce the gap between the availability of unmanned systems and accompanying integrated ammunition

licence under the Industries (Development and Regulation) Act, 1951, is Sagar Defence Engineering, which is looking to diversify into munitions manufacturing, probably to arm its in-house advanced unmanned and autonomous solutions. Besides that, they plan to offer their explosives products in the country's ammunition market projected to grow from \$2.66 billion in 2026 to \$4.44 billion by 2031.

RECENT SHIFT "The recent shift towards hybrid warfare, which is the

growing use of unmanned systems, highlights the need for developing explosives that are integration-driven, where payloads can work seamlessly with intelligent platforms," Captain Nikunj Parashar, Founder and CEO of Sagar Defence Engineering, told *businessline* about the government's initiative. "The plan is strongly aligned with the upcoming government initiatives that are supporting start-ups like ours to develop such systems for national security, keeping in mind the evolving nature of warfare," Parashar said, as

his company is set to expand into manufacturing of arms and explosives over the next two years. The company stated that the initial focus will be on defence ordnance that will integrate autonomous and unmanned systems, and not just traditional forms of arms and explosives, along with specific solutions in the maritime surface and sub-surface domains.

TWO FACILITIES Sagar will set up two facilities at the current defence manufacturing unit in Maharashtra and another at the upcoming Autonomous Maritime Shipyard and Systems Development Centre in Andhra Pradesh. Currently, the focus is towards specialised ammunition categories where technology integration, reliability and mission adaptability are more critical. "The maritime surface and sub-surface domain is significantly important, be-

ing a maritime nation. The development and integration of advanced technology is essential, and we aim to contribute to this gap by building indigenised, application-specific solutions designed for integration with autonomous maritime systems, as well as emerging maritime ordnance segments and existing platforms," he said. *businessline* had reported in December that of the remaining 16 ammunition variants, the Defence Ministry had initiated in-house production of four-seven types of bullets, rockets and missiles to further enhance the Army's warfighting capability through smart munitions. These include the Russian-origin armour-piercing fin-stabilised discarding sabot anti-tank ammunition and Swedish-designed 84-mm ammunition. The projects are expected to be completed shortly, sources said earlier.

'Theaterisation of command' 90% complete, says Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit

Our Bureau
New Delhi



Indian Air Force's Chief of Integrated Defence Staff Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit **PTI**

Air Marshal Ashutosh Dixit, Chief of Integrated Defence Staff, on Thursday, announced that more than 90 per cent of the work on the theaterisation of the Indian Armed Forces has been completed, signalling that the much-awaited major military restructuring exercise has reached its final stage. The transformation, expected to be announced by next month, would lead to single-service commands getting subsumed into tri-services architecture, each led by a three-star commander. "Our move towards joint structures and theatre commands — with planning now reported to be more than 90 per cent complete — is a historic opportunity," he said during his opening address at the second edition of Ran Samwaad 2026 at Bengaluru. He, however, cautioned that structures alone do not guarantee synergy. "Cultural integration is what makes structure come alive. Jointness must evolve from mere coordination to genuine unity of effort," he advocated in his remarks at Ran Samwaad on "Multi-Domain Operations: An Imperative for Addressing Conventional and Irregular Threats."

That requires transparency in information sharing, clarity of authority and — most fundamentally — mutual trust, he remarked, hinting at issues that would require ironing out. He also flagged the need for command accountability and responsibility as the use of unmanned and autonomous systems increases. **DOMAIN JOINTNESS** Chief of Army Staff General Upendra Dwivedi, during his address, emphasised that Operation Sindoor demonstrated India's progression towards "domain jointness" and described the military offensive inside Pakistani territory a "defining case study" of operational significance of integration. "Operation Sindoor was India's most powerful tool of progression towards domain jointness. But we need to achieve domain integration and fusion," General Dwivedi said in his speech on "Land Forces visualisation of Multi Domain Operation." He also pitched for creation of an information warfare organisation and a psychological defence division following Operation Sindoor. He said, "Fifteen per cent of our effort was on managing the disinformation campaign." He cautioned, however, that key challenges remain, particularly in synchronising operations across strategic, operational and tactical levels, and addressing the growing prevalence of hybrid or grey-zone warfare. "These are typically below the conventional military threshold, with the goal to exploit adversary vulnerability," he said. He added that non-kinetic operations are increasingly taking precedence.

FSSAI urges States to ramp up surveillance, over 1.6 lakh samples analysed

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) has been directing States to ramp up surveillance and inspections. The State Food Safety Departments, as part of their enforcement drives, have conducted nearly 3,97,009 inspections in FY26 across categories, according to sources. Between April and December, the States have analysed nearly 1,65,747 food samples.

Of this, 17.16 per cent samples were found to be non-conforming with safety and quality standards, sources added. This led to State food safety departments to take action against the non-compliant food business operators. "Nearly 23,580 adjudication cases were decided and about 1,756 criminal convictions secured. At the same time, ₹154.87-crore penalties were imposed on the non-compliant food business operators," an official noted. Nearly 945 food recalls



were also undertaken in FY26. Recently, FSSAI also directed the States to ramp up surveillance and inspection of milk products including *paneer*, sources added. Early last month, during the Central Advisory Committee Meeting, FSSAI had

Efforts have been made to bring more street-food vendors into the formal licensing regime

directed the States to focus on risk-based inspections and sustained surveillance drives especially for high-risk commodities such as milk and milk products, edible oils, spices and honey. FSSAI also directed the States to take strict action against non-compliant com-

panies to deter violations and reinforcing consumer confidence. Last month, the Centre decided to reduce compliance burden for street-food vendors by removing dual compliance requirements. It notified that street-food vendors registered with municipal corporations or town vending committees will be considered as deemed registered under the FSSAI. "This measure benefits more than 10 lakh street-food vendors by eliminating the requirement for multiple registrations across departments," an official statement pointed out.

Brand Concepts bets on premium push with Off-White entry, eyes metro expansion

Jyoti Banthia
Bengaluru

Brand Concepts is stepping up its push into the premium and luxury segment, betting on rising consumer appetite for aspirational brands as it expands its portfolio with the India entry of Off-White. The company, which is the official licensee for brands such as Tommy Hilfiger, United Colors of Benetton, Superdry, Aeropostale, Juicy Couture, The Vertical and also Sugarush, is looking to sharpen its positioning in the premium segment by adding global labels and expanding distribution across channels. "We are accelerating our premium portfolio expansion, and Off-White is a very strategic addition for us," said Abhinav Kumar, Co-founder of Brand Concepts. "It helps us strengthen our play in the aspirational seg-



Abhinav Kumar, Co-Founder, Brand Concepts

ment, especially among younger consumers who are increasingly looking for brands that go beyond traditional luxury." **STRONG MOMENTUM** The move comes at a time when India's premium and luxury market is seeing strong momentum, driven by rising disposable incomes, global exposure and the growing influence of

streetwear culture. Industry executives say consumers are increasingly seeking differentiated fashion that blends global trends with individuality, creating an opportunity for brands like Off-White. Brand Concepts plans to open five flagship stores for Off-White over the next three years, starting with Bengaluru, followed by Delhi and Mumbai, and eventually expanding into other tier-1 cities. The company is also building an omni-channel presence to cater to both online and offline demand. **5 FLAGSHIP STORES** "Our plan is to have about five flagship stores across the country over the next three years," Kumar said. "We are starting with Bengaluru, which is a natural fit given its young demographic and strong streetwear culture, and will then expand into

other key metros." Alongside its offline push, the company is focusing on ensuring parity with global markets in terms of product availability and pricing—an issue that has historically been a challenge for international brands in India. "We are bringing the same international collections to India and ensuring pricing is on par with global markets," Kumar said. "The Indian consumer today is well-travelled and value-conscious, and expects the same experience as they would get abroad." The company's broader strategy hinges on a mix of accessories—its legacy strength—and a growing play in apparel and adjacent categories such as footwear. While accessories will continue to contribute a significant share of revenues, newer categories are expected to gain traction over the next few years.

Telangana Vahan to issue permanent RCs from April 11

Our Bureau
Hyderabad

Telangana Transport Department's Vahan portal will commence generation of permanent registration certificates of non-transport vehicles from April 11. The State government successfully operationalised the generation of non-transport temporary registrations through the Vahan portal from March 23 as part of an initiative towards digital governance to enhance citizen convenience. The objective is to eliminate the need for new vehicle owners to visit the transport offices in person with vehicles for registrations and provide the facility at dealer outlets. Citizens will be able to download registration certificates (RCs) and driving licences through the mParivahan app.

Andhra Pradesh to unveil India's first quantum testing unit on April 14

Our Bureau
Hyderabad



Andhra Pradesh CM N Chandrababu Naidu

Marking World Quantum Day on April 14, Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu will formally launch an indigenous quantum computer testing facility, the first in the country, at SRM University in Amaravati and simultaneously virtually launch the quantum facility centre at Medha Towers in Gannavaram, near Vijayawada. With this, Andhra Pradesh will emerge as the first State to commission indigenous quantum computer testing facility and Amaravati Quantum Valley to emerge as an international quantum computers hub. Naidu will witness a live quantum system initiation with the cooling process of the processor on the Amaravati IQ system being triggered virtually, as the system is housed at Medha

Towers. At the same time, Amaravati 1S system will function as an open access set-up fully visible to all attendees during the demonstration. With the setting up of Amaravati Quantum Reference Facility (AQRF), India will have sovereign quantum infrastructure. Amaravati will become the anchor node of a national quantum hardware network, positioning India to design, test, certify and manufacture quantum systems for the world. The technologies de-

veloped through AQRF include cryogenics, precision electronics and quantum-grade fabrication, which have strategic spill over into defence, healthcare and semiconductor manufacturing. **FLAGSHIP PROGRAMME** The Andhra Pradesh government's flagship programme Quantum technology hub under the National Quantum Mission, Amaravati Quantum Valley will be hosting an IBM 133-qubit quantum computer and has engaged 80-plus industry and academic partnerships, positioning it to be among the top five global quantum hubs. The launch of AQRF on World Quantum Day adds an indigenous hardware dimension to Amaravati Quantum Valley's portfolio, complementing its existing quantum cloud, skilling and innovation infrastructure, according to a release.

Indium eyes 25-28 per cent revenue growth in FY27

Rohan Das
Chennai

Indium, a Chennai-based digital engineering company, is expecting a revenue growth of 25-28 per cent in FY27, driven by expansion into AI-led engineering and a new enterprise legacy modernisation product. It posted revenue of \$130-140 million in FY26 with a similar growth rate, according to Ram Khizamboor, Chief Operating Officer, Indium. Speaking to *businessline*, Khizamboor said growth will be anchored by a deliberate shift away from traditional IT services towards more complex, AI-led work. He said that the company is willing to cannibalise its own existing business with AI-driven delivery models. "We do very little of the tra-

ditional annuity work. In many cases, we are actually telling clients to reimagine those contracts with AI, even if it means cannibalising our own revenue," he said. Key to this AI strategy will be Indium's new product, Lifter, an AI-driven solution that will help enterprises modernise legacy data and software, he said. Khizamboor believes that a large share of modernisation projects fail due to fragmented business logic spread across systems. **LATERAL HIRING** "The problem in modernisation is that the business logic has multiple points in the enterprise. If you do not account for that, projects fail," he said, adding that the product is already seeing good early traction, especially across over-

seas clients. On talent, Khizamboor said that the company will continue to look at lateral hiring for ongoing projects, but will onboard freshers and entry level talent and train them for more AI-driven tasks. "Our view is that a fresher trained well on AI can be as productive as a mid-level engineer. So, we are not cutting fresher hiring but training them as AI-native engineers," he said. Its workforce currently stands around 5,200-5,300 employees, with about 90 per cent based in India across Chennai, Bengaluru and Hyderabad. On the broader industry outlook, Khizamboor acknowledged that AI is likely to put pressure on traditional IT services, especially those built on large teams and long-term contracts.

Google Earth Pro analysis reveals vanishing, shrinking lakes in J&K

Gulzar Bhat
Srinagar

Satellite analysis using Google Earth Pro, backed by official data, has revealed a worrying decline in Jammu and Kashmir's lakes, with several water bodies disappearing, shrinking drastically or undergoing severe ecological degradation. An audit report on the conservation and management of lakes for the period ending March 2022 found that at least seven lakes were no longer visible or had nearly dried up when their geo-coordinates were analysed on Google Earth Pro across multiple timelines. The satellite findings were corroborated by data from the Ecology, Environment and Remote Sensing Department, which earlier identified 11 lakes as having disappeared. Field verification in November 2022 confirmed that at

least four of these had completely dried up, with former lakebeds now covered by vegetation, plantations and even roads. The audit also analysed broader trends across sampled lakes and found a significant number witnessing sharp reduction in area. Key lakes such as Khushal Sar were found to be undergoing land-use changes, while Anchar Lake was noted to be steadily shrinking and deteriorating. The report points to sustained encroachments and land conversions between 2014 and 2020, clearly visible in satellite imagery. Areas once occupied by water bodies have been overtaken by weeds, plantations and infrastructure development, indicating a gradual but consistent loss of aquatic ecosystems. **SERIOUS CONCERNS** Experts warned that continued degradation of lakes

could have long-term consequences for groundwater recharge, flood regulation and biodiversity in the Kashmir Valley. "Although development authorities were established for development of

areas of five out of six detailed-checked lakes, there were no clear directions and specific mandate with any of these authorities for conservation and management of lakes," the audit report said.

With both satellite evidence and official data pointing in the same direction, the report underlines a deepening ecological crisis in the region's fragile wetland network.

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QUICKLY.

UK court orders SpiceJet to pay \$8 m to engine lessor



New Delhi: A UK court has ordered India's SpiceJet to pay about \$8 million to an aircraft engine lessor over unpaid rent and maintenance charges for three engines, in the latest setback for the cash-strapped airline. London's Commercial Court granted summary judgment on Wednesday in favour of Sunbird France 02 SAS over the unpaid rent and maintenance accruals, finding that SpiceJet had no viable defence. **REUTERS**

Fire at Mumbai airport terminal 1 delays flights

Mumbai: A fire broke out in terminal 1 of Mumbai airport on Thursday evening resulting in flight delays. A few aerobridges were temporarily closed as a matter of precaution. Passengers also complained of system failure and outage or internet. According to a source eleven flights were delayed. In a statement, the Mumbai International Airport Ltd said a minor fire was reported at Terminal 1 due to a short circuit at 6.10 pm. "The fire was immediately bought under control. Airport operations remain unaffected," MIAL said. **OUR BUREAU**

Intel and Google expand AI CPU partnership

Intel and Google have expanded their partnership to advance the use of AI-focused central processing units and to develop custom infrastructure processors, as shifting use of AI drives renewed demand for traditional computing chips. Companies deploying AI are increasingly moving away from using AI for training models to deploying them, fuelling the need for generalist CPU chips designed to handle heavy workloads. Under the agreement, announced on Thursday, Alphabet's Google unit will continue to deploy Intel's Xeon processors that support a broad range of workloads such as inference and general computing. **REUTERS**

MeitY weighing harms of social media use by children amid growing concerns

GAINING ATTENTION. Consultations on with multiple stakeholders, social media intermediaries

Sindhu Hariharan
Chennai

The Ministry of Electronics of Information Technology (MeitY) is closely engaging with, and listening to the opinions of multiple stakeholders including the platforms themselves on the impact of social media on children and it cannot be a "sudden and major decision", MeitY Secretary S Krishnan said.

"When governments from different political parties feel this is an issue that requires attention, it is something we have to take seriously," Krishnan said. The National Human Rights Commission too had a special consultation session about a month ago, to which we were invited, he added.

Informal consultations have also begun with social media intermediaries. "We had an informal chat saying give us your views, we'll look at it," he noted.

The matter has gained at-



ACTION NEEDED. S Krishnan, Secretary, MeitY, said the Centre is taking the issue of social media seriously as it has been pointed out by multiple governments **SUSHIL KUMAR VERMA**

tention as several State governments have started talking of a need for regulatory intervention in the matter going as far as suggesting bans on it.

RISK ANALYSIS

The risks of social media use on the youth has been flagged in the Economic Survey, and the matter has also been discussed extensively in multiple Standing Com-

mittees, including those on Information Technology and Home Affairs, said the Secretary. Interestingly, MeitY is also said to be carefully studying a recent judgment in the US wherein a California Court ruled on the impact of social media platforms on digital addiction. The Court penalised social media platforms Meta and YouTube for creating algorithms and methods by

which they build additions. Clarifying on the recent backlash over MeitY's proposed amendments to the 2021 IT Rules, Krishnan emphasised that it is not aimed at expanding government powers or censorship. "The amendment is largely clarificatory in nature. It is wrong understanding to view it as an attempt to widen the government's authority," the official said.

"The intent is to ensure clearer distinction between news publishers, intermediaries and users and modifications will be made to reflect that more clearly," he said, adding that all stakeholders have sought additional time to submit representations.

AI IMPACT

The MeitY Secretary said that the impact of the advancements of Artificial Intelligence (AI) on the large scale jobs in Indian IT sector is a key issue on their radar and they engage with multiple stakeholders on this.

We are consulting with a range of ministries and departments on this. We are talking to the Department of Economic Affairs naturally, we are talking to other entities like NITI Aayog and the Ministry of Skill Development, Education and others, he said.

"We believe that the pace of adoption of AI has been a little slower (in India) than what many people originally feared; it gives us a little more time to adjust," he said.

On the various ways India can deal with this, the IT secretary said that reskilling and upskilling workforce and training the next-generation of workers more on domain knowledge than coding/programming should be key ways to prepare. Noting a need to work on job creation and promotion in areas less vulnerable to impact of AI such as manufacturing, healthcare and others, he said that the policymakers must also make sure it is "prestigious" to hold those jobs.

TRAI floats satellite spectrum allocation framework, seeks industry views on direct-to-mobile services

Our Bureau
New Delhi

The Telecom Regulatory Authority of India (TRAI) has issued a consultation paper proposing a new framework for Satellite Communication Network (SCN) authorisation, setting the stage for satellite-based mobile connectivity, particularly in rural and remote regions.

At the heart of the consultation is a key regulatory question: should direct-to-device (D2D) satellite services operate using spectrum earmarked for mobile satellite services (MSS) or frequencies currently used for terrestrial mobile services such as 4G and 5G?

EASIER ACCESS

The proposed framework is

expected to accelerate satellite-enabled mobile connectivity, potentially allowing users in underserved areas to access services directly on standard mobile handsets without requiring specialised satellite phones.

However, the move is likely to revive tensions between satellite operators and traditional telecom companies. Telecom operators have earlier opposed such proposals, arguing that allowing satellite-based D2D services using terrestrial spectrum could disrupt their business models. They have also demanded that satellite players be subjected to same regulatory norms if D2D services are permitted. TRAI noted that enabling D2D services could bring satellite communications closer to parity with conventional mo-



FIXING CONNECTIVITY. The proposed framework is expected to potentially allow users in underserved areas to access services directly on mobile handsets

bile networks. The consultation follows a communication from the Department of Telecommunications (DoT) dated July 3, 2025, which proposed the creation of a Satellite Communication Network authorisation under the Telecommunications Act, 2023, and sought TRAI's

recommendations on operational terms and spectrum assignment for feeder and user links.

According to the regulator, two possible models of D2D services are under consideration: D2D services via satellite using MSS spectrum, traditionally meant for

specialised satellite phones and D2D services via satellite using IMT spectrum, typically allocated for mobile technologies such as 4G and 5G.

While MSS-based D2D would extend satellite connectivity to regular smartphones, TRAI has sought stakeholder views on whether IMT-based satellite D2D services should be permitted immediately or examined after the World Radio communication Conference (WRC)-2027.

TRAi stated that intended usage must be clearly established before assigning fixed-satellite service (FSS) or MSS spectrum.

Stakeholders have been given until May 6 to submit comments, with May 20 deadline for the counter-comments.

CBI registers FIR in ₹550 crore IDFC First Bank embezzlement case

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The CBI has registered an FIR in the alleged embezzlement of ₹550 crore from the Haryana government's accounts maintained with IDFC First Bank in Chandigarh after taking over the investigation in the matter, official sources said Thursday. The Haryana government had transferred the probe to the central probe agency. The referral was sent to the agency on Wednesday by the Department of Personnel and Training, they said.

The CBI registered the FIR taking over the case earlier probed by the Haryana State Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (SV & ACB).

DIVERTED FUNDS

"The case pertains to fraudulent banking operations and fictitious transactions allegedly undertaken in a systematic manner to siphon off Government funds into the accounts of shell entities, including Swastik Desh Project, SRR Planning Gurus Pvt Ltd, Cap Co Fintech Services, RS Traders, and other associated firms/individuals,

resulting in a substantial loss to the public exchequer," the vigilance department of Haryana said while referring the case to the agency.

According to the allegations, Haryana government funds were supposed to be deposited by various departments of the state in the bank in FDs but were allegedly diverted by the accused, the sources said.

A preliminary probe showed "huge" funds had been transferred to various shell companies and siphoned off under the guise of gold purchase and investment, the sources said.

Bitcoin holds near \$71,000 as geopolitical risks remain

Our Bureau
Bengaluru

Bitcoin briefly pushed past \$72,000 before settling back near the \$70,800-\$71,100 range on Wednesday, as a temporary US-Iran ceasefire sparked a cross-market repricing, cooling oil prices, easing bond yields, and lifting risk assets. Yet, the rally lost momentum, leaving the cryptocurrency confined within its familiar \$70,000-\$73,000 band amid fragile demand, inconsistent ETF flows, and uncertainty ahead of key US inflation data.

The recent resilience in crypto prices comes amid

improving global risk sentiment following the US-Iran ceasefire agreement, though markets remain cautious as the situation around the Strait of Hormuz evolve. Analysts say the relief rally lacks strong follow-through, with broader indicators pointing to hesitation among investors.

SHORT TERM

Riya Sehgal, Research Analyst at Delta Exchange, noted that Bitcoin's move above \$72,000 and the parallel rise in Ethereum were largely sentiment-driven. However, derivatives data and ETF flows indicate that sustained buying demand has yet to re-



turn. She highlighted that Bitcoin continues to find support in the \$69,000-\$70,000 range, keeping the short-term structure intact. A push toward \$72,500-\$74,000 remains possible if this support holds, while a drop below \$68,000 could

Eli Lilly's Mounjaro loses ground to generics and Novo Nordisk's products



MORE IN THE OFFING. About 13 firms launched 26 versions of generic semaglutide and more are in the pipeline

PT Jyothi Datta
Mumbai

In ten days after less-expensive generic versions of semaglutide entered the fray, the marketplace shows that Eli Lilly's obesity drug Mounjaro continues to hold pole position, but has ceded ground to the generic versions of semaglutide, besides the innovator's own products used in treating weight loss and diabetes.

Semaglutide is the active ingredient in Danish company Novo Nordisk's Ozempic (for diabetes) and Wegovy (obesity). It lost patent protection in India and some other markets on March 20, paving the way for a slew of domestic products to enter the market at prices down between 50 to 80 per cent of the innovator's price; and in multiple delivery forms (vials, reusable pens, oral drugs) and strengths.

Tirzepatide (brand Mounjaro) dominates the segment, but seems to have taken "a major hit" due to the semaglutide generics launch, observed Sheetal Sapale, Vice-President, Commercial, at Pharmarack Technologies. American company Eli Lilly's Mounjaro is more expensive than semaglutide, but has been leading this segment for months, since launch in March 2025. The domestic GLP-1 agonist segment (covering these obesity and diabetes drugs) is almost ₹1,600 crore, for the 12 months up to March 2026, the pharma industry tracker said.

Mapping the fluctuating fortunes of these medicines, Pharmarack said, Tirzepatide clocked sales of ₹114 crore in March, down from ₹135 crore in February 2026. Semaglutide posted sales of ₹59 crore in March, up from last month's ₹48 crore. The dip in

Tirzepatide sales also brought down GLP-1 drug sales in March to ₹180 crore, from last month's ₹191 crore. Others in the same segment remain unchanged — Dulaglutide clocked ₹5 crore in March, same as the previous month; and Liraglutide posted ₹3 crore in March, same as February's sales, the data tracker revealed.

'GOLD RUSH PHASE'

About 13 companies launched 26 versions of generic semaglutide, and more are in the pipeline, said Sapale, adding that only a handful will leverage the branded generics opportunity.

So, while innovator Novo led the semaglutide sales in March at ₹45 crore with Ozempic, Wegovy and oral drug Rybelsus — the generic semaglutide brands debuting included Torrent Pharma (₹4.7 crore), Dr Reddy's Laboratories (₹1.9 crore), Zydus Lifesciences (₹1.4 crore), Lupin (₹1.4 crore) and Sun Pharma (₹0.90 crore). "This is a classic 'gold rush phase' — participation is high, but value capture will be concentrated," she noted.

As these products become accessible, the Centre cautioned that GLP-1 drugs are break-through products, but have side-effects, and should be given on prescriptions and to eligible patients. "Misuse/unwanted use may be difficult to arrest," said Sapale, adding that regulations may refine the market, but was unlikely to derail the initial growth of generics. More "aggressive launches" are expected and the "exponential growth" may repeat in April 2026, she said.

Novo Nordisk stood its ground in the initial phase, she said, adding that pegging the price of its products at par with some key generics may play a significant role in future for the innovator.

'India has ample buffers to deal with W. Asia crisis'

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

India has "ample" buffers to deal with the West Asia crisis, but a prolonged conflict could pose downside risks, the World Bank said on Thursday.

"Risks are tilted to the downside as prolonged periods of elevated oil prices can significantly impact the Indian economy, but risks are cushioned by ample buffers," World Bank Lead Economist for India Aurelien Kruse said while presenting India Development Update. These buffers comprise a net energy import share of 2.8-3 per cent of GDP, foreign exchange reserves capable of covering over 10 months of imports, and low inflation alongside a minimal current account deficit, among other factors. On Wednesday, the World Bank had raised In-

dia's growth forecast for the current fiscal by 30 basis points to 6.6 per cent from its earlier estimate of 6.3 per cent, though this remains lower than the previous fiscal.

In its South Asia Economic Update report, it said India's growth is estimated to have accelerated to 7.6 per cent in FY26 from 7.1 per cent in FY25 owing to strong domestic demand and export resilience.

RIGHT STRUCTURE

Comparing the current situation to an "earthquake", Kruse said, "But India has the right structure of house and fire trucks are coming." Further, he mentioned that India has remained the fastest-growing large economy in the world in FY26, despite facing some of the highest tariffs on its exports globally. He also said the income tax cuts and GST rate reduc-



World Bank Lead Economist for India Aurelien Kruse

tions last year supported domestic consumption, while exports and investment, areas which were expected to be adversely affected by tariffs, performed much better than anticipated.

"India showed very strong performance and resilience," Kruse said. All the estimates have assumed oil price in FY27 at \$90-100/barrel for arriving at its growth estimates. The World Bank com-

mended the Indian government's strategy of handling the energy crisis due to the West Asia conflict.

"The authorities have struck a right balance between taking measures to manage supply without doing massive rationing or massive restrictions and also trying to soothe the initial volatility by maintaining retail prices of oil relatively constant to avoid kind of very sharp, non-linear adjustment that would have been probably more detrimental than beneficial in the short term. So having said that, the risks are obviously massive. They're tilted to the downside," Kruse said.

World Bank Regional Practice Director for South Asia (Prosperity), Sebastian Eckardt, stated that India's strong growth momentum is supported by positive policies, including the EU FTA and new labour reforms. Despite global head-

winds, "we do see India and the region, continuing to be a very strong, performed gross performing region compared to others," he said.

RISING DEFICIT

The Bank said that India's current account deficit in FY27 is expected to increase to 1.8 per cent of gross domestic product due to higher energy import bill.

The general government (Centre and States combined) fiscal deficit is projected to increase marginally to 7.6 per cent of GDP versus 7.3 per cent in the absence of the conflict, as higher energy prices will feed into higher spending on fertilizer and fuel subsidies while excise duty cuts will contain revenue growth.

Over the medium term, however, the overall fiscal deficit is projected to decline gradually, the Bank added.

Reliance caps individual fuel purchases to ₹1,000 per visit

Bloomberg

Reliance Industries has capped fuel purchases across its retail outlets — limiting customers to about ₹1,000 worth of gasoline or diesel — as the West Asia crisis continues to choke off supplies despite a tentative ceasefire.

The country's largest private-sector oil refiner is restricting individual purchases to ₹1,000 (\$10.8) per visit at fuel stations it operates with partner BP Plc, according to people familiar with the matter. The joint venture has more than 2,000 fuel pumps across the country.

While the company has issued no formal directive, operators of Jo-BP pumps have begun enforcing the caps to curb panic buying



and prevent its stations from running dry as demand surges, the people said, asking not to be named because the information isn't public.

The rationing comes as India, the world's third-largest oil consumer, grapples with the fallout of the weeks-long near-closure of the Strait of Hormuz.

RIPPLE EFFECT

A spokesperson for Reliance said there's no directive restricting how much fuel customers can purchase. While Reliance runs only

2 per cent of the more than 102,000 gas stations in India, it's the first operator to go beyond price hikes to rationing supply, reflecting an escalation of the uncertainty.

State-run companies — Indian Oil Corp, Bharat Petroleum Corp and Hindustan Petroleum Corp — that control the vast majority of fuel stations have not officially announced price hikes or purchase caps, but drivers have reported ₹1,000 rupee limits at some gas stations.

Nayara Energy, another private-sector fuel retailer, raised diesel and gasoline prices last month in an effort to narrow losses on retail sales, local media reported. State-owned refiners had last cut pump prices in March 2024 under government intervention.

Closing price is the average of trade price(s) for the last half an hour; 52-Week High/Low figures pertain to BSE.

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